



{Sunday} Hindustan Times

FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

Pradhan steps down, Gen Z steps up

Movement that began as social media satire announces Gen Z's arrival as a political force

Minister Pralhad Joshi gets additional charge of education, BJP leaders rally behind Pradhan

CJP calls off protests, says government agreed to all demands; next meeting in a month

Crowds thin, internet restored, Metro stations reopen as central Delhi curbs begin to ease

Smriti Kak Ramachandran
and Dhruvo Jyoti
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NEW DELHI: A 36-day stir by students achieved a landmark victory on Saturday as education minister Dharmendra Pradhan resigned following weeks of sweeping protests that brought central Delhi to a halt, enervated a moribund opposition, and heralded the entry of a new generation of young people into politics.

The sprawling sit-in in Delhi's historic Jantar Mantar was called off hours after the resignation was announced by the minister on X with leaders of the Cockerroach Janta Party (CJP) saying the government had accepted two other demands—compensation of ₹1 crore to the kin of every student who died by suicide following irregularities in the National Eligibility cum Entrance Test, and the withdrawal of all first information reports against students who undertook a massive march to Parliament earlier this week.

"We have won, Gandhi has won, Ambedkar has won," CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke said from the makeshift stage in Jantar Mantar as news trickled into the heavily barricaded site.

This is the first time that a popular street protest has forced the resignation of a Union minister in the National Democratic Alliance (NDA) government's three terms. Union consumer affairs minister Pralhad Joshi was given additional charge of the education ministry.

Celebrations erupted soon after as young men and women—many of them Gen Z—waved the Tricolour, climbed barricades and broke into impromptu jigs as makeshift

... The events of the past 10 days have troubled me... This is not a matter of personal prestige for me... I have submitted my resignation.

DHARMENDRA PRADHAN,
Former education minister

For BJP workers, the country, youth, and students are far more important than any position... The resignation [of Pradhan] exemplifies this...

AMIT SHAH,
Union home minister

I thank CJI Kant for calling us cockroaches. Had you not called us cockroaches... Pradhan would not have resigned.

ABHJEET DIPKE,
CJP founder

morestories

Cops await govt order on withdrawing FIRs

Longest mobile net curf in Capital's history eases

Pradhan's controversial tenure comes to an end



Protesters—many of them students, first-time agitators and young professionals—at Jantar Mantar on Saturday.

REUTERS

What the protesters sought

DEMAND 1

Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation

STATUS

Pradhan stepped down on Saturday afternoon.

Pradhan's controversial tenure comes to an end

DEMAND 2

Compensation of ₹1 crore to the kin of every student who died by suicide following NEET irregularities.

STATUS

Nadga said the govt agreed to give "honourable compensation within the rules" to the families of NEET suicide victims.

DEMAND 3

All FIRs by Centre and NDA-ruled states against protesters be withdrawn and no action to be taken in future.

STATUS

Nadga said "if FIRs have already been filed, whether by the Delhi Police or in BJP-ruled states, they will be withdrawn".

DEMAND 4

Public apology from the Rapid Action Force (RAF) and the Delhi Police for alleged violence against protesters through the course of the 36-day protest.

STATUS

The government did not comment on this demand.

The two sides will again meet after four weeks to discuss broader reforms in the examination system

Fear of alienating youth may have prompted exit

Smriti Kak Ramachandran
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NEW DELHI: Prolonged deliberations within the government over the social and security ramifications of allowing the student protests over paper leaks to continue and the possible adverse electoral impact it might have for the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), which is already gearing for the next round of state assembly elections, may have forced the resignation of Union education minister Dharmendra Pradhan on Saturday, said people aware of

THE ELECTORAL IMPACT OF STIR ALONG WITH ITS 'SOCIAL SECURITY' IMPACT WERE ALSO DELIBERATED UPON

the details.

Another key reason was the fear of alienating a big demographic—young people, most specifically Gen Z—not limited by "geographical, faith and caste divisions", said one of the people in the BJP HT spoke to.

3 PROTESTERS IN BIHAR SUICIDE AFTER POLICE CRACKDOWN

Widespread clashes between police and protesters erupted across Bihar on Saturday during a statewide shutdown, leaving three students injured in gunfire in Siwan, officials aware of the matter said, adding that a probe is on to ascertain police involvement in the firing. The police said they fired in self-defence. The bandh was called by the All India Students Association and other left-wing student organisations demanding Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation as the Union education minister. Hours later, the state home department imposed a partial internet ban mostly restricting social media platforms till Sunday 5.30pm.

RESIGNATION BRINGS LITTLE RELIEF TO KIN OF SUICIDE VICTIMS

For several parents, who lost their children by suicide after NEET-UG 2026 examination was cancelled following a paper leak, resignation of Union education minister Dharmendra Pradhan is not enough. They echoed demands of structural reforms in country's education sector and punishment for those who assaulted protesters in Delhi. Most parents said the government never understood pain of the children preparing for the national-level medical exam, and their parents. They also expressed anguish at the police assaulting students in Delhi during "Chai Sansad" march, called by the Cockerroach Janta Party (CJP), an online collective, on July 20.

OPPN PARTIES PLAN TO CORNER SHAH OVER POLICE ACTION

Opposition parties plan to turn the heat on Union home minister Amit Shah for the use of pellet guns and the brutal thrashing of the students by the security forces, following the resignation of Union education minister Dharmendra Pradhan, people familiar with the matter said. This could well mean that the second week of the monsoon session is as unproductive as the first. Opposition parties will meet on Monday morning to decide the scope of their participation in the Parliament proceedings. "The first thing is that we hold Mr Amit Shah directly responsible for the violence that has taken place against our students," Lop Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, said.

Jubilation at Jantar Mantar: Stir epicentre erupts in celebration

Aaditya Khatwani,
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NEW DELHI: With jammers in place in many parts of central Delhi, news of Union education minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation trickled in slowly at the protest site in Jantar Mantar on Saturday. But when it did, the celebrations were immediate. Protesters broke into dance; some sang the national anthem, some wept, others hugged and jumped, and chanted "Inquilab Zindabad" and "Bharat Mata Ki Jai".



Protesters at Jantar Mantar celebrate Pradhan's resignation on Saturday evening.

SANCHIT KHANNA/HT PHOTO

U.P. REFORMS RAM TEMPLE CASE S.I.T AFTER SC DECISION

LUCKNOW: The Uttar Pradesh government has reconstituted the Special Investigation Team (SIT) probing the alleged misappropriation of donations at the Ram Temple, appointing inspector general (Lucknow range) Kiran S to head the new team.

The move, in compliance with the Supreme Court directions.

Houthi hit Saudi oil infra, US holds off on Iran strikes

ATHENS/WASHINGTON: Yemen's Iran-aligned Houthi militants fired on Saudi oil installations in two ports on the Red Sea coast on Saturday, but the United States held back from launching air strikes on Iran itself for the first time in two weeks.

There was no immediate explanation from Washington of why it had abruptly halted a streak of 13 nights of escalating strikes since an interim deal to end hostilities collapsed, in retaliation for Iranian attacks on shipping in the Strait of Hormuz.

"It seems that our dear Iran had a peaceful night last night," Health Ministry spokesperson Hossein Kermanpour said on X. After the quiet night in Iran, there were also no reports on Saturday of attacks from Iran on its Gulf neighbours, which have also been taking place daily in response to the US attacks. However, the strikes from Iran's Houthi allies on Saudi Arabia were again the war that has disrupted energy war.

TRUMP SAID HE HAD NOT YET MADE A DECISION ON NEW MAJOR STRIKES AND SAID THE U.S. WAS IN TALKS WITH IRAN

plies from the Gulf could be spreading to a second major shipping route, and reigniting Yemen's own civil war. Houthi military spokesperson Yahya Sareed said the group had successfully struck sites belonging to Saudi state oil giant Aramco in Jizan and Yanbu. Video shared on social media and verified by Reuters showed a large column of smoke rising from the direction of the Aramco refinery in Jizan. Two Asia-based trading sources said that they had been informed of potential damage to fuel and oil storage sites at Jizan. Aramco did not respond to requests for comment.

INDIA, U.S. WORKING TO CONCLUDE TRADE AGREEMENT EARLY: COMMERCE MINISTRY

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NEW DELHI: India's engagements with the US Trade Representative helped secure a lower tariff on Indian goods, the commerce ministry said on Saturday, adding that both nations were seeking an "early conclusion" of the planned bilateral trade agreement. The statement followed the imposition of 10% extra tariffs on goods from India on Friday.

US court dismisses Trump admin bid to restore \$100k H-1B visa fee

BOSTON: A federal appeals court on Friday rejected a bid by US President Donald Trump's administration to halt a judge's order preventing it from imposing a \$100,000 fee on new H-1B visas, which tech companies rely on to bring in foreign workers. The Boston-based 1st US Circuit Court of Appeals declined to put on hold a lower court judge's June 8 ruling in a lawsuit filed by 20 Democratic state attorneys general, striking down the fee on the basis that it constituted an

unlawful tax Congress never authorised. The three-judge panel said to show it was likely on appeal to succeed in showing it had not exceeded its authority by imposing the fee. The US president issued a proclamation in September that raised the cost of obtaining H-1B visas, which tech companies rely heavily on to bring on foreign workers, with a sizeable chunk coming from India.

BILL IN U.S. SENATE SEEKS 3-YEAR H-1B GUARANTEE
A US senator has introduced a bill in the Senate that seeks to pause issuance of new H-1B visas for three years and codify the current law, which allows the Trump administration, which was struck down by a federal court. US senator Tim Sheehy, a Republican from Montana, said the US should not be issuing visas that make it easier to "undercut the rights" of American workers.



Jhandu Kumar

JHANDU POWERS PAST POVERTY AND POLIO FOR INDIA'S FIRST CWG MEDAL

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NEW DELHI: Refusing to be defined by polo, poverty or ridicule over his name, Bihar's Jhandu Kumar on Saturday clinched India's first medal at the Glasgow Commonwealth Games, winning bronze in para powerlifting. Once mocked after a childhood bout of polio left him disabled and burdened his vegetable-selling family, the 29-year-old sporting adversity into transformed success. "You can either sulk at what life throws at you or make your way through with a smile," he told HT on the phone from Glasgow. Jhandu, weighing 72-kg, bench-pressed 180kg in his second attempt to collect 130.9 points to finish third.



Shots heard around the world

It's been 200 years since the first photograph: a blurry view, captured over hours. It still felt like magic—an image crafted by light. More spells have been cast since. Photographs have shown how we travel, what we eat, what we see in the mirror (and how often we look); helped pass better laws, and change our views on war. Take a look

{ UNCONTROLLED INFERNO }

260k evacuated in Spain, France as wildfire rages

Agence France-Presse
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BORDEAUX: Unchecked wildfires raging Saturday in France's southwest and near Spain's capital Madrid have forced nearly 260,000 people to flee and prompted Paris to deploy its military. France hustled 197,000 people from areas around Bordeaux including vacation spots crowded this time of year—in

what was "probably" the biggest peacetime evacuation the country has seen, its interior minister said. In Spain, where 60,000 people were evacuated from villages west of Madrid, Prime Minister Pedro Sanchez said the priority was "to save lives" as he visited the fire zone. Officials in Madrid had earlier given a higher estimate of around 70,000 people evacuated.



Spanish officials fight a fire in El Tiemblo, 80km from Madrid.

AFP

4.43 mn Andhra voters face deletions after SIR

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HYDERABAD: The Election Commission of India's (ECI) special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in Andhra Pradesh has identified around 4.49 million voters—10.78% of the state's 41.63 million electorate—for potential deletion from the final electoral roll, officials said on Saturday.

The door-to-door SIR exercise conducted by booth-level officers (BLOs) across the state concluded on Friday after the ECI granted a 10-day extension on the request of political parties.

According to chief electoral officer (CEO) Vivek Yadav, enumeration was completed for 37.14 million of the state's 41.63 million voters, accounting for 89.22% of the electorate.

"The enumeration forms of as many 44.89 lakh electors, accounting for 10.78% have not been uploaded. During the exercise, it was found that as many as 15,22,174 electors in the present list were found to be deceased; 14,43,880 voters had permanently shifted their residences," Yadav said.



Vivek Yadav

UNDER THE SIR GUIDELINES, THE PUBLIC WILL HAVE ONE MONTH, TILL AUGUST 30, TO FILE OBJECTIONS SEEKING ADDITIONS, DELETIONS OR CORRECTIONS TO THE DRAFT ROLLS

He said 737,216 voters were found to have registered at multiple places, while another 77,885 voters were not traceable. In addition, 8,327 electors did not submit their enumeration forms.

According to official data, Nellore recorded the highest number of voters proposed for deletion at 290,683, followed by Tirupati (287,835), Kadapa (244,919), Visakhapatnam (240,209) and Guntur (237,556). Eighteen other districts each recorded more than 100,000 names in the proposed deletion list.

"The district electoral officers and BLOs will share the

alleged that reports from several districts suggested BLOs, under pressure from local Telugu Desam Party leaders, had mapped persons who were not ordinary residents without insisting on valid documentary proof.

"At the same time, many genuine electors are reportedly being marked as 'non-mapped' despite being eligible voters, raising fears of arbitrary deletion from the electoral rolls," he said.

He urged the Election Commission to conduct an immediate inquiry into the complaints and restore the names of genuine voters who were wrongly excluded.

Appi Reddy also urged the ECI to publish the draft electoral roll based only on the existing polling stations and implement the revised polling station structure only after publication of the final electoral roll.

He said this would ensure clarity for voters, booth level officers, booth level electors, political parties and election officials, while ensuring transparency throughout the revision process.

Jubilant as Pradhan steps down



Protesters celebrate the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan at Freedom Park in Bengaluru on Saturday.

WILL HOLD DEPUTY COMMISSIONERS ACCOUNTABLE FOR PAPER LEAKS: CM

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CHITRADURGA: Karnataka Chief Minister D K Shivakumar on Saturday warned Deputy Commissioners of the districts that they would be held responsible for any question paper leak in the state's recruitment examinations.

The direction comes in the wake of NEET paper leak controversy that triggered nationwide protests and culminated in the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan.

Charging the Bengaluru Revenue Division-level progress review meeting held here, Shivakumar also directed officials to be vigilant about upcoming exams so that no lapses are there.

He told officials that the state is undertaking a major recruitment drive where more than 70,000 posts are being filled. The Chief Minister instructed officials that CCTV cameras must be installed at every examination centre.

"Question papers must be given enhanced security. Every stage, including preparation, printing, distribution and conduct of examinations, must be documented. Let the NEET scam remain a lesson for everyone. If question papers are leaked, the officials concerned, particularly the Deputy Commissioners, will be held responsible," he said.

Shivakumar said his government would not tolerate laxity in public administration and warned officials against making people run from office to office.

"The government must go to the people's doorsteps. People should not have to come to government offices," he said.

"Officials must find solutions to people's problems. If they create unnecessary disputes, action will be taken. If the free flow of information and action will follow," he added.

To curb irregularities in groundwater, Shivakumar directed officials to make maps, photographs and GPS coordinates be made mandatory before and after drilling new borewells.

Shivakumar hails Pradhan's resignation as 'long overdue'

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BENGALURU: Karnataka Chief Minister DK Shivakumar on Saturday welcomed the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan, calling it a "long overdue acknowledgement" of accountability amid the NEET-UG controversy.

In a post on X, Shivakumar said, "Today belongs to the students of India. The resignation of the Union Education Minister is a long overdue acknowledgement that accountability cannot be postponed when the future of our youth is at stake."

He credited students and the Opposition for the development and aspirations of every student, and a 26-day hunger strike led by Waghachuk at Jantar Mantar. The agitation was spearheaded by the Cockerach Janata Party (CJP), which has been demanding accountability over alleged paper leaks.

The resignation began as a NEET-UG paper leaked emerged



DK Shivakumar

PRADHAN DIDN'T RESIGN OUT OF REMORE, SAYS PRIYANK KHARGE

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BENGALURU: Karnataka Home Minister Priyank Kharge on Saturday alleged that neither Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan nor Prime Minister Narendra Modi had expressed remorse or accepted responsibility for the NEET paper leak, underlining that the minister's resignation was forced by sustained nationwide student protests.

Pradhan on Saturday resigned from his position following massive protests in the national capital and various other parts of the country over NEET paper leak.

Speaking to reporters here, Kharge claimed that Pradhan's resignation letter did not acknowledge responsibility for the paper leak and instead justified his exit by citing the need to prevent "anti-national forces" from exploiting the situation.

"It is very clear that Pradhan's resignation is not one of consciousness, or it is not one because he's taken accountability; it is because he's been forced by the students of this nation," Kharge said.

Press Trust of India
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HYDERABAD: Alleging that Telangana Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy had threatened voters with denial of welfare benefits if they were not included in the voters' lists during SIR, the BJP on Saturday urged the state Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) to issue a video, directing him to withdraw his remarks.

In a memorandum and a video submitted to the CEO, Telangana BJP's Election Commission Affairs Committee Chair

{ FORMER ANDHRA PRADESH MINISTER Y S VIVEKANANDA REDDY }

Pea for deeper probe into murder rejected

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HYDERABAD: A special court for Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) cases in Hyderabad on Friday dismissed the petition filed by Y S Sunitha Reddy, daughter of former Andhra Pradesh minister Y S Vivekananda Reddy, seeking a deeper investigation by the CBI into her father's murder more than seven years ago, people familiar with the matter said on Saturday.

The court's decision came after the CBI submitted an affidavit on July 3, stating that it had already completed a comprehensive investigation into the case and there was no need for any further probe.

Principal Special Judge K Patabhi Rama Rao accepted the CBI's submission and held that the existing investigation was warranted. The court rejected Sunitha's contention that several crucial aspects of the investigation had not been adequately examined by the agency.

In April this year, Sunitha filed a protest petition under Sections 190 and 200 of the Code of Criminal Procedure (CrPc), requesting the court to reject the CBI's third supplementary chargesheet filed on March 11, 2026, and order further investigation into the case.

In her petition, she argued that several crucial aspects of the murder had not been adequately investigated. She alleged that the



Y S Vivekananda Reddy

agency had failed to uncover the larger conspiracy behind the murder, conduct a complete probe into the money trail, properly investigate the destruction of evidence at the crime scene, question influential individuals and other key suspects, examine allegations of witness intimidation, and comprehensively analyse call data records (CDRs) and electronic communications linked to the case.

The CBI, however, told the court that it had already conducted additional investigation as directed earlier, re-examined four individuals, and reviewed forensic reports.

It also argued that repeated petitions seeking further investigation were obstructing the progress of the trial. Dismissing Sunitha's petition, Justice Patabhi Rama Rao said repeatedly seeking further investigation on issues that had already been examined was not legally sustainable.

He observed that investigation cannot continue indefinitely and recalled that the Supreme Court

had already directed that the trial be expedited. The judge further clarified that courts cannot dictate the specific manner in which an investigating agency should conduct its investigation. Vivekananda Reddy, popularly known as Viveka, represented Pulivendula in the Andhra Pradesh Assembly twice between 1989 and 1989, served as Kadapa MP twice from 1989 to 2009, and was a member of the Legislative Council between 2009 and 2015.

Viveka was found brutally murdered on the intervening night of March 14 and 15, 2019, weeks before the Lok Sabha and Andhra Pradesh Assembly elections. Police found that he had been killed with a death with an axe. The CBI, which took over the investigation from the state police in July 2020 following directions from the Andhra Pradesh High Court, filed its chargesheet on October 26, 2021, naming Yerra Gangi Reddy, Y Sunil Yadav, G Uma Shankar Reddy and Shaik Dastagiri as accused.

Of the four accused, Dastagiri, who had previously worked as Viveka's driver, turned approver four days after the filing of the chargesheet and was granted anticipatory bail by a Pulivendula court. Based on Dastagiri's confession, the CBI alleged that Kadapa MP Y Avinash Reddy, his father Y Bhaskar Reddy and associate D Shiv Shankar Reddy were also involved in the murder conspiracy.

BJP MLC CT RAVI BOOKED OVER 'PROVOCATIVE' SPEECH: POLICE

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BENGALURU: BJP MLC and former Karnataka minister C T Ravi has been booked by the Chikmagalur Town police for allegedly delivering a provocative speech that promoted hatred and communal disharmony during a public meeting held in connection with the controversy over the National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test (NET).

The case was registered on Friday night on a complaint filed by Jania Masjid president Mudasi Pasha, who alleged that Ravi's speech contained objectionable remarks against the Muslim community and had the potential to disturb communal harmony. The controversy stems from a "Youth for Nation" programme organised by the BJP at Azad Park Circle in Chikmagalur on Thursday.

During the event, Ravi criticised the protests in New Delhi over the alleged NET question paper leak and questioned the participation of members of the National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test (NET) in the agitation.

Confirming the development, Chikmagalur additional session judge P K Jayaram said, "On Friday night, we booked a case against C.T. Ravi for a provocative speech which promotes hatred and disharmony among communities. We will issue a notice to him to appear for enquiry."

T'gana seeks govt nod on Kaleshwaram project

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HYDERABAD: The Telangana government has decided to seek technical guidance from the Centre on the future operation of the three barrages under the Kaleshwaram Lift Irrigation Scheme on the Godavari river amid demands from the Opposition to resume water lifting to irrigate parched lands in northern Telangana.

At a high-level review meeting with senior irrigation officials, engineers and technical experts on Friday, irrigation minister N Uttam Kumar Reddy directed officials to immediately write to the Union ministry of Jal Shakti (MoS) and the National Dam Safety Authority (NDSA), seeking clear technical guidance on the operation of the Medigadda,



N Uttam Kumar Reddy

Annamam and Sundula barrages. He said the Telangana government had maintained the barrages in a free-flow condition after the NDSA advised that it was unsafe to store water in the structures, which were damaged during the October 2023 floods.

Written advice by any competent technical authority will be mandatory to decide whether storage and pumping operations

could be safely resumed," Uttam Kumar Reddy told officials, according to a statement issued by the irrigation department.

The minister directed officials to attach relevant portions of the NDSA report, earlier technical observations and supporting documents to the communication so that the technical basis for the government's decision not to lift water from the project was placed on record.

"The correspondence with the Union Jal Shakti ministry should clearly explain why the barrages have not been used for storage or pumping and seek a formal opinion from the competent technical authorities," he said.

He also instructed that copies of the communication be provided to the Resident Commissioner for immediate hand delivery to senior officials in the min-

istry.

During the review, irrigation department officials said recent statements by Union Jal Shakti minister C R Patil and the ministry's correspondence had largely reiterated the general policy that operational decisions on barrages rest with the state government.

"It did not specifically address the recommendations contained in the NDSA report regarding the redesigning the structures in free-flow condition," the statement, quoting officials, said.

The minister directed officials to accurately quote the relevant portions of the NDSA report and include supporting technical material, including findings of the Central Water Commission (CWC), Ground Penetrating Radar (GPR) investigations, photographs, gravity assessments beneath the raft foundation.

Priyanka Gandhi visits Wayanad landslide site, meets survivors

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WAYANAD: Congress MP Priyanka Gandhi visited the landslide site near the Anakkampoyil-Meppadi road project and met some of the survivors.

The Congress MP landed at Kannur airport in the morning and travelled by road to the landslide site in Meppadi, Wayanad constituency.

On the way to the disaster site, Yadra was greeted by students of Wayanad Engineering College, who thanked her for leading the protest by students and the Cockerach Janata Party in Delhi against alleged irregularities in the NEET exam, party sources said.

She subsequently reached the disaster site near the Anakkampoyil tunnel road project at around 2 pm and met some of the survivors, hearing how they had a narrow escape.



Congress MP Priyanka Gandhi visits the landslide site at Meenakshi Bridge and reviews the ongoing relief and rehabilitation efforts in Wayanad.

She is scheduled to visit those injured in the incident who are undergoing treatment at WIMS Hospital here, and will also visit the site where the Congress is building homes for survivors of the Chooramala landslides, people aware of the

matter said.

Eight people were killed in the landslide that occurred on July 7 near the site of the Anakkampoyil-Meppadi tunnel project, which is intended to connect Wayanad and Kozhikode districts.

PROPOSAL FOR TN CM'S CAUVERY TALKS WITH K'TAKA DRAWS BACKLASH

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CHENNAI: Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay has proposed bilateral talks with his Karnataka counterpart to seek an amicable solution to the long-standing Cauvery river water-sharing dispute, a move that has drawn criticism from farmers' organisations and political parties in the state.

As Vijay is scheduled to visit the neighbouring state on August 3 for talks with Karnataka Chief Minister D K Shivakumar, DMK president M K Stalin said the Chief Minister must not get entangled in the "conspiracy" of setting up talks with the Congress-led government in Karnataka over Cauvery water issue.

"This poisonous experiment must not be undertaken. Negotiation efforts will only serve to undermine the rights we have legally fought over for decades. We will stand up to setbacks in the court," Stalin said on X, reacting to the development. This was precisely why DMK firmly rejected such proposal in the past, he claimed.

"We will convene an all-party meeting to consult farmer associations and take the next step. I urge the CM to abstain from the decision to go to Karnataka for the negotiations," Stalin said.

AIDAKM chief Edappadi K Palaniswami demanded Vijay to take a stand on the Cauvery issue for a consensus on exercising TN's rights. Also, views of farmer representatives and legal experts should be taken into account. Palaniswami said in accordance with Supreme Court's final verdict. Refusing to provide us our rightful share of Cauvery water is reprehensible. Palaniswami said in a statement.

{ ALLEGED VOTER ROLL REMARKS }

BJP moves T'gana CEO against Revanth

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HYDERABAD: Alleging that Telangana Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy had threatened voters with denial of welfare benefits if they were not included in the voters' lists during SIR, the BJP on Saturday urged the state Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) to issue a video, directing him to withdraw his remarks.

In a memorandum and a video submitted to the CEO, Telangana BJP's Election Commission Affairs Committee Chair



Revanth Reddy

man Marri Shashidhar Reddy claimed that the CM threatened people in rural areas that they would not get the benefits of government welfare schemes such as 'Kalyana Lakshmi', 'Shaadi

Mubarak' and 'Indiramma' housing.

"This video exposes the gravity of the threat of the Chief Minister," the memorandum said.

Threatening citizens with the withdrawal or denial of such government welfare benefits based on where they choose to register as voters is legally flawed and violates established electoral and constitutional principles.

Such threats raise severe concerns in view of the provision of 'undue influence' under election law and also because of the disconnection between welfare

benefits and voter registration, it added. If such statements are deliberately made by the Chief Minister, during an active election cycle or a sensitive administrative roll-revision phase like the SIR, they are 'intimidatory'. The BJP urged the Election Commission to immediately issue a notice to the Chief Minister on various alleged violations and demand that he should, through the electronic media and his social media handles, to rescind from his earlier statement and clarify to people that voter ID is not mandatory for any government scheme."

SPOTLIGHT STUDENT PROTEST



(Left to right) Posters depicting activist Sonam Wangchuk started cropping up in the evening; protesters waved the national flag and raised slogans after the Union minister resigned; people take a selfie at the site of the protest; CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke shows a copy of the Constitution of India. SANCHIT KHANNA, SHANT CHAUHAN/HIT & REUTERS

Tear gas at 2pm, jubilation by 6: When the waiting paid off

Aaditya Khatwani,
Gargi Shukla, Snehi Sinha
and Hemani Bhandari
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NEW DELHI: With jammers in place in many parts of central Delhi, news of Union education minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation trickled in slowly at the protest site in Jantar Mantar on Saturday afternoon but when it did, the celebrations were immediate.

Protesters—young and old, men and women, parents and children—broke into a dance; some sang the national anthem, some wept, others hugged each other and jumped, and chanted "Inquilab Zindabad" and "Bharat Mata Ki Jai".

Connaught Place, Sansad Marg, Tolstoy Marg became centres of celebrations. But it was a journey to get there, protesters acknowledged.

On day 36 of the protest—it had seen activist Sonam Wangchuk and at least 3 students held a hunger strike. Wangchuk being forcibly removed, violence in the form of lathi-charge and tear gas at the hands of police on July 20 in which more than 100 protesters were injured, internet suspended, and Metro stations closed—Pradhan's resignation was preceded by a flurry of activity within the government, and at the site.

Minutes before Pradhan's post on X, two incidents of lathi charge and tear gas were also reported at Sansad Marg. At 1.56pm, police fired tear gas at protesters after some were seen breaking windows of the police booth in front of the Jantar Mantar protest site. An HT reporter also saw a man break the CCTV camera stop a pole. Another round of tear gas was fired at 2.05pm in police personnel.

After the Cockerroach Janta Party (CJP) delegation held a meeting with Union ministers following Pradhan's resignation, the movement's founder, 30-year-old Abhijeet Dipke, said, "This is a big win. It shows that the constitution is run as per the Constitution. It is just the beginning... I would like to thank Chief Justice of India Surya Kant. Thanks for calling us cockroaches. If he hadn't said this, I wouldn't have come to India and this movement wouldn't have started."

Key moments of the 36-day agitation

June 6 Cockerroach Janta Party (CJP) holds its first protest at Jantar Mantar	June 11 CJP releases a five-point manifesto for reforms in India's education sector	June 20 With demands unmet, CJP begins a round-the-clock indefinite sit-in at Jantar Mantar	June 28 Activist Sonam Wangchuk begins a hunger strike at Jantar Mantar	June-July The protest gathers pace as supporters join the sit-in in Delhi and demonstrations start in other cities
July 20 Tens of thousands of protesters join the 'Chalo Sansad' march, demanding Union education minister's resignation. The march turns violent as security officers and protesters clash. Parliament gates are locked for the first time since 2011	July 18 Wangchuk is taken to the Safdarjung Hospital due to deteriorating health, with police citing court orders to the effect	July 21 Wangchuk is allowed to shift to a private medical hospital in Gurugram	July 21-23 Opposition political parties and prominent public figures condemn alleged use of violence against protesters	July 25 Union education minister Dharmendra Pradhan tenders his resignation, following which CJP officially calls off the nationwide agitation. CJP and Centre are set to meet again after four weeks to discuss education system reforms
July 24 Large-scale protests are held in Patna and Mumbai, among other cities in support of the CJP movement	July 23-24 Wangchuk ends his hunger strike at the Gurugram hospital, after meeting with Union ministers JP Nadra and Indira Singh	July 23 PM Modi, in a video message, assures support of action against corrupt officials and an overhaul of the examination system	July 24 The CJP delegation meets Union ministers Nadra and Singh over their demands	July 24 National Testing Agency terminates services of 47 officials

Even as the CJP announced that the protest had ended and some people started leaving, others kept coming in to celebrate the victory. Popular Hindi songs such as "Chak De India" and "Rang De Basanti", blared through loudspeakers as the demonstrators were in no rush to end the celebrations.

Arush Naman, a 20-year-old law graduate who learnt of the minister's resignation while on his way to the protest, told HT, "Our generation often has to hear that we don't do anything, we are always on our phones... Today has shown what we can do with our phones. We got the education minister's resignation."

The protest was marked by a steady inflow of students, from

across Delhi, NCR cities and far-flung states, with the demographic younger than at other protests for reforms, according to the demonstrators.

Lakshay Chauhan, 23, who is pursuing his master's in Haryana, said that the past few days had shown that the "spirit of Bhagat Singh, Dr B.R. Ambedkar is alive in today's youth."

At the protest site, an 18-year-old from Rajasthan's Kota was seen approaching other protesters for their autographs in a thin notebook he had specifically brought for the purpose. "When I left from home, my parents told me this was a fake protest. They said I was wasting my time, and that no one would listen to us. I am getting autographs of people who have stood with me and

other youngsters," he said. Others like 24-year-old video editor Khushi Chopra said one minister's resignation was not enough. "What does one resignation amount to? It is an incredible achievement but what if a similar person replaces Pradhan? We need an overhaul of the system," she said.

Yashika, 21, a Delhi student said, "My friends and I have been coming here from the initial days (of the protest) and fighting tear gas shelling just this afternoon. The next minute, we heard that the minister has resigned. I can't tell you the happiness we felt. We didn't know one another but we all hugged. We tasted the joy of victory today."

A 25-year-old man, Pulkit, said that he is preparing for

NEET PG. "I have faced the pressure; so, I know what the students are feeling. This resignation was overdue," he said.

Another 25-year-old, Vishal, who came from Mumbai, said, "The larger thing to have happened from the protest is that people are not afraid anymore. They feel empowered and that they can still make a difference."

At 6pm, CJP spokesperson Ashutosh Ranga got on to the stage to loud cheers and informed the protesters of the developments following their meeting with the government.

"Because all our primary demands have been met, we request you to peacefully withdraw the protest. Thank you. We will meet you soon," he ended the address.

A senior police officer said security will remain deployed until the crowd dispersed. "We have been asking people to leave the site and are waiting for them to disperse," the officer said.

Between 7pm and 8pm, people were seen sitting, many still chanting slogans. Large groups gathered on Sansad Marg near Connaught Place and on Tolstoy Road near Gate 2 of Jantar Mantar Metro station. Several auto-rickshaws were stationed at both locations.

Meanwhile, some who had come from other states began preparing to leave. "I came from Mumbai four days ago to show solidarity. I was staying at the ghidwara. I will take the train back on Sunday," said Praveen, 38.

Cops await govt order on withdrawing FIRs

Hemani Bhandari

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NEW DELHI: Hours after Union education minister Dharmendra Pradhan resigned and the government assured the Cockerroach Janta Party (CJP) that the first information reports (FIRs) registered in connection with the protest and related violence would be withdrawn, Delhi Police said that they will wait for the official communication from the government for further action.

"As of now, we will wait for the government for any official communication on how to proceed with the cases already registered in connection with the July 20 violence and other cases registered on July 22," a senior police officer, who did not wish to be named, said.

Union minister JP Nadra said the discussions with the CJP included cases registered during the agitation, compensation for affected families and the CJP's broader charter of demands. "We discussed these issues in detail. After the discussion, the first point was that no action should be taken and no FIR should be filed. If any FIRs have already been registered, whether by the Delhi Police or in BJP-ruled states, it will be with-

drawn," he said.

However, a second officer explained that FIRs are never "withdrawn" and the term was used only to explain to the public. The officer said that an FIR is an official record.

"There are only three ways an FIR can be treated. One is to file a charge sheet and prosecute further. The second is to file a closure report or cancellation after probe. The third is for the state to withdraw prosecution," the officer said.

The officer said that when the government officials communicate to them that they have withdrawn the prosecution, no investigation will be conducted.

A CJP spokesperson said they will be given the same in writing on Tuesday. Police had, until Friday, described the incidents that unfolded on July 20 as a "larger conspiracy". The Delhi Police, until Friday, registered 15 FIRs in connection with the violence that accompanied the CJP's "Chalo Sansad" march between July 20 and July 23.

One of the FIRs, accessed by HT, was registered at Kartavya Path police station on the complaint of an inspector and includes Section 109(1) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita

(attempt to murder), along with charges related to rioting, unlawful assembly, assault on public servants, mischief causing damage to public property and disobeying prohibitory orders.

Separately, senior officers said four more FIRs were registered later, taking the total to 15, while the special cell took over the first FIR to investigate what police termed a "larger conspiracy" behind the violence.

Investigators had said they were examining more than 15 terabytes of video footage, scrutinising speeches delivered from the main stage at Jantar Mantar, and probing the role of alleged "handlers" and social media influencers suspected of coordinating the protests. Police also claimed to be investigating funding channels, logistical support and the circulation of a purported "lookalike" instructing participants to carry pepper spray, chili powder and blunt objects.

Officers had maintained that intelligence inputs initially estimated a crowd of 15,000 people, but the turnout was significantly higher, with groups approaching Parliament from multiple directions.

According to police, these circumstances formed the basis of the conspiracy investigation.

Police stick to order banning assemblies

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NEW DELHI: Protesters, students and commuters continued to be detained on Saturday, even after Union minister Dharmendra Pradhan announced his resignation, as police continued to remove people from the Nizamuddin area and prevented many from entering Jantar Mantar and the Lutyens' zone.

Near Nizamuddin in the Hazrat Nizamuddin area, police set up multiple barricades to halt auto-rickshaws, bikes, cabs and trucks.

All passing vehicles were profiled as on Saturday, with students being stopped specifically from entering Jantar Mantar. Two minors were picked up from Mehrauli and Hauz Khas, while they were heading for the protest. Police later released them. A senior police officer, who did not wish to be named, said, "There is a clear order that the New Delhi district has

imposed Section 163 of BNSS (prohibiting assembly of five or more people). The protest has been going on without permission. Also, under Section 65 of the Delhi Police Act, we have the powers to detain people who are trying to join an illegal protest."

Hundreds of students, protesters and commuters have been stopped or detained across south, central and southeast Delhi in the past few days as the Delhi Police enforced stringent preventive measures to block supporters of the Cockerroach Janta Party (CJP) from reaching Jantar Mantar.

Police also placed barricades at Badarpur, Mehrauli and Hauz Khas areas from Friday night. Over 200 people were briefly detained from South and South-East Delhi on Thursday and Friday.

More than 25 students were kept at Lodhi Colony police station after being picked up while returning from Jantar Mantar.

A SIGH OF RELIEF SEEPS THROUGH CENTRAL DELHI AS CJP ENDS PROTEST

Snehi Sinha and Gargi Shukla

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NEW DELHI: A sense of normalcy started returning to central Delhi late Saturday, after days of protest, brief skirmishes, internet suspension, Metro closures and heavy barricading of roads threw life out of gear due to the sit-in protest by the Cockerroach Janta Party (CJP) and its supporters over the past month.

With the CJP announcing an end to its agitation in the evening, barricades that had sealed off several roads around the protest site were gradually removed and traffic resumed across the city's stretches of Sansad Marg, Connaught Place, Ashoka Road and adjoining roads.

Officials of the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC) said that the protest also led to the longest suspension of Metro operations in the network's history.

"Metro services have been suspended or regulated on earlier occasions as well, but this is the first time such a large number of stations remained closed throughout the day for multiple consecutive days," a Delhi Metro official said.

The protest also resulted in one of the longest closures of Sansad Marg, as Jantar Mantar—the Capital's designated protest site—is located close to Parliament and the Central Secretariat.

The prolonged restrictions also forced a significant number of businesses across Connaught Place and surrounding commercial areas. "In this period during the protest, the business for shops reduced by almost 80%, for confectioneries, it went down by around 70% and for restaurants, the business went down by nearly 80-85%. Even those who had no such hurdles, as online payment was not possible due to internet shutdown, cabs weren't available and Metro was also shut," said Vikram Badhwa, general secretary of the New Delhi Traders Association.

Restaurants and food outlets reported an immediate improvement after internet services were restored and restrictions eased.

{ CJP CHECKS OUT, REVELLERS CONTINUE TO POUR IN }

Delhi's GenZ turns site of the protest into weekend hang-out

Hemani Bhandari and Aaditya Khatwani

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NEW DELHI: Celebrations continued at Delhi's Jantar Mantar and the neighbouring arterial roads hours after Union education minister Dharmendra Pradhan resigned on Saturday afternoon, even as the protesters were asked to vacate the site. There was no sign of the crowd thinning by around 10pm on Saturday.

The protest venue remained packed with people clicking photographs, shooting reels, and raising slogans late into Saturday night. People at the site danced, sang the national anthem, some also wept and jumped, while others chanted slogans. New posters such as "Jinu Jang gya", "Pradhan bhag gya" (Youth wakes up, Pradhan runs

away) had come up after the minister's resignation. Connaught Place, Sansad Marg, Tolstoy Marg became centres of celebrations. By 10.15pm, police estimated the crowd strength at around 4,000.

Although the Cockerroach Janta Party (CJP) leadership had left the stage around 6.30pm after urging supporters to disperse, crowds continued to arrive.

Nishi, 29, a volunteer, said, "We will stay till the last person leaves. The place is still overcrowded, and we may be needed." By 7pm, police had removed some barricades at entry and exit points to ease movement, even as heavy security deployment remained. CJP spokespersons Ashutosh Ranga and Sanur Das made announcements over the public address system

at Sansad Marg, appealing to people to leave peacefully. By 8pm, police began making announcements for people to exit. As of 10pm, Sansad Marg, Tolstoy Lane, and the protest site remained packed.

Meanwhile, Ranga and Das met Commissioner of Police Anurag Kumar around 7.30pm and left the area shortly after, even as the crowd lingered. "We have told people, but they are not listening," said a core CJP team member.

Volunteers, meanwhile, began cleaning the area and directing people to exit. On Tolstoy Road around 7.30pm, a human chain of volunteers formed a ring around four to five others who were sweeping the roads and collecting garbage in trash bags.

"I have been cleaning since 4pm and haven't got a chance to go inside the main site. I am

not an official volunteer, but I saw people cleaning and decided to join. Now that the protest is over, I will stay as long as I can, to help," said Ashika Azmi, 24, holding a garbage bag.

For Chris Sebastian, 26, cleaning up after the protest was as integral as the slogan-carrying. On Saturday evening, he was among those forming a barrier around the cleaners to give them space. "I have been volunteering for the past few days. I have been cleaning and creating space for the cleaners amid the huge crowd," he said.

Aman Singh, 29, another volunteer managing the crowd, explained the process. "Since there are multiple exits, groups like ours have been placed near each exit. Some are cleaning, others form a ring to give them space. We are also handling crowd control to ensure

orderly exit till Rajeev Chowk," he said.

A senior police officer said security will remain deployed until the crowd dispersed. "We have been asking people to leave the site and are waiting for them to disperse," the officer said.

Between 7pm and 8pm, people were seen sitting, many still chanting slogans. Large groups gathered on Sansad Marg near Connaught Place and on Tolstoy Road near Gate 2 of Jantar Mantar Metro station. Several auto-rickshaws were stationed at both locations.

Meanwhile, some who had come from other states began preparing to leave. "I came from Mumbai four days ago to show solidarity. I was staying at the ghidwara. I will take the train back on Sunday," said Praveen, 38.



At around 10.15pm on Saturday, police estimated that a crowd of 4,000 people remained at the site. SANCHIT KHANNA/HIT PHOTO

Longest mobile net curb in Capital's history eases

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NEW DELHI: By the time mobile-internet services in parts of central Delhi around Jantar Mantar were restored on Saturday, it had been a five-day suspension, the longest recorded anywhere in the national Capital by a wide margin.

The restoration came shortly after Union education minister Dharmendra Pradhan announced his resignation on X and the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) called off its protest, stating that the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) government had agreed to its demands.

Earlier in the day, authorities issued a seventh order extending the suspension of mobile-internet services around Jantar Mantar until midnight, taking the total duration of repeated disruptions in the area to five days. Prior to this episode, the longest such stint of localised internet blackouts lasted less than a day, occurring during last year's 2021 farmers' protest. The Capital has never recorded a



Authorities issued a seventh internet suspension order at Jantar Mantar on Saturday. ANI

citywide internet restriction. Services were restored well before the scheduled midnight deadline. However, telecom service providers (TSPs) had not received any formal order revoking the suspension until late Saturday evening, said people aware of the matter.

Over the five-day period, July 21 was the only day on which the government did not issue a suspension order.

The shutdown began on July 20, when the government directed TSPs, including Airtel, Reliance Jio, and Vodafone Idea, to suspend mobile-internet services from 10am to 6pm in parts of central Delhi around Jantar

Mantar. A second order followed on July 22, directing operators to suspend services from 6pm until 6am the next morning.

On July 23, the government extended the suspension from 9.30am to 4.30pm before issuing another order extending it until midnight. On Friday, authorities again suspended mobile internet until noon before issuing a sixth order extending the shutdown until midnight. The seventh order was issued on Saturday morning.

The directives required telecom companies to suspend mobile-internet services within a 1.5km radius of the protest site. Among the affected areas were Janpath Market near Connaught Place, Le Meridien, Shangri-La hotel, the National Media Centre, and the Indian Women's Press Corps office.

Digital rights organisation Software Freedom Law Center India (SFLCI) challenged the internet shutdown orders before the Delhi high court, arguing that the suspension of mobile-internet services in parts of central Delhi during the July 2026 pro-

tests was unlawful.

History of shutdowns

While Delhi has experienced internet shutdowns previously, earlier disruptions were shorter and linked to specific law-and-order situations.

In December 2019, mobile-internet services were suspended for several hours in parts of the capital during protests against the Citizenship (Amendment) Act (CAA). That shutdown was ordered by Delhi Police, which is empowered to direct telecom operators to suspend services under temporary telecom suspension rules.

Another instance occurred during the farmers' protests in January 2021, when the government suspended mobile-internet services in adjoining areas of Delhi. The suspension was later extended to border protest sites, including Singhu, Ghazipur, and Tikri, as the agitation continued.

Unlike the 2019 and 2021 disruptions, the recent shutdown was extended through multiple consecutive government orders over several days.

BENGAL INVOKES GOONDA ACT FOR NEET PROTESTERS IN KOLKATA: CM

KOLKATA: West Bengal chief minister Suvedu Adhikari on Saturday said that the state's newly enacted Goonda Act has been used for the first time to book people allegedly involved in clashes during NEET protests a day ago in central Kolkata.

"In all, seven cases have been registered in Hare Street and Entally police stations. Sections under the new Goonda law have been included to book the accused persons. Police have identified around 70 people. None of them were students. Neither are they members of the CJP nor are they related to the NEET-protests," Adhikari said in the assembly.

A clash broke out between the police and Left-backed students' unions on Friday during protest rally over the NEET-UG paper leak issue. Police on Saturday said 11 people were arrested so far in relation to the clashes.

Meanwhile, former CM Mamata Banerjee on Saturday alleged that Kolkata police "resorted to atrocities" during a protest organised by the TMC's youth faction in south Kolkata. "Our workers were staging a peaceful demonstration when police resorted to atrocities," Banerjee told the media. **HTC**

3 students sustain gunshot injuries at Bihar NEET stir; net ban till today

Avinash Kumar

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PATNA: Widespread clashes between police and protesters erupted across Bihar on Saturday during a statewide shutdown, leaving three students injured in alleged police firing in Siwan, officials aware of the matter said, adding that a probe is on to ascertain whether those injured were hit by bullets from police firing.

The bandh was called by the All India Students Association (AISA) and other left-wing student organisations over the alleged NEET leak and Wednesday's police action in Patna.

Hours after the violence, the state home department imposed a partial internet ban restricting social media platforms till Sunday 5.30 pm, saying that certain posts could "disturb public order and peace". "It is felt that misuse of social networking sites and instant messaging services is likely to be detrimental to the peace and tranquillity in Siwan district," said the order issued by home secretary Kundan Kumar.

Siwan SP, Puran Kumar Jha, confirmed the injuries, saying: "Police fired in self-defence after some anti-socials, mixed with protesters, and fired on police at JP Chowk... We are yet to ascertain whether those injured were hit by bullets from police firing or from the protesters as firing took place from both sides."



Protesters damage a police vehicle in Patna on Saturday. ANI

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No aid can bring my son back: Kin of suicide victims

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NEW DELHI: For several parents, who lost their children by suicide after NEET-UG 2026 examination was cancelled following a paper leak, resignation of Union education minister Dharmendra Pradhan is not enough. They echoed demands of structural reforms in country's education sector and punishment for those who assaulted protesters in Delhi.

Most parents said the government never understood pain of the children preparing for the national-level medical exam, and their parents. They also expressed anguish at the police assaulting students in Delhi during 'Chalo Sansad' march, called by the

Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), an online collective, on July 20, calling for structural changes in education so that no papers are cancelled in future due to leak or any other examination malpractice. Father of a 21-year-old NEET aspirant of Uttar Pradesh's Kheri district, who died by suicide in May, lauded the peaceful protest by youth despite "brutal" attack by the police on them and sought education reforms to prevent something similar in future.

His son had appeared for NEET for the third time. "Any compensation cannot bring back my son to life. The void cannot be filled. I hope the protest will prevent such tragedies in future," he said.

Mother of 18-year-old NEET aspirant, who died by suicide in Nagpur on May 20, said those

PARENTS OF NEET VICTIMS CALLED FOR STRUCTURAL CHANGES IN EDUCATION SO NO EXAM PAPER IS LEAKED IN FUTURE

responsible for her death should be punished. "Resignation is fine but I would like to thank the children who fought for my child and faced police bullets and batons. I want that those responsible for paper leak and assaulting students should be severely punished," she said.

Her father said, "Justice was served today. The resignation will not bring back my daughter, but it

will at least give peace to her soul." On compensation, he said, "After her death, my relatives helped me repay the debt taken for her education. If I receive compensation, I will use it to clear the dues." His wife participated in the CJP protest in Nagpur. Father of a NEET aspirant from Rajasthan's Kotputli-Behror district, said, "Governments must understand the pain students undergo while preparing for competitive exams and take strict measures to prevent such incidents in the future."

He added that the government was not willing to accept their mistake after so many children died. "It was only after so many students protested and faced police lathis and refused to leave Jantar Mantar that they agreed,

Pradhan did not resign on his own. It was under pressure of these kids," he said.

Brother of a 19-year-old deceased NEET aspirant who died by suicide in Uttar Pradesh's Maharajganj district, said the CJP protest has helped people to understand the pain of NEET aspirants as his sister's suicide note saying 'she will not be able to bear it anymore' had gone viral during the protest. "Today, I can sleep as I feel that my sister has got some justice."

Mother of 23-year-old NEET aspirant from Dehradun said that Pradhan's resignation showed that the government has accepted its mistake, although belatedly. "Compensation cannot bring her back but structural reforms can prevent such tragedies," she said

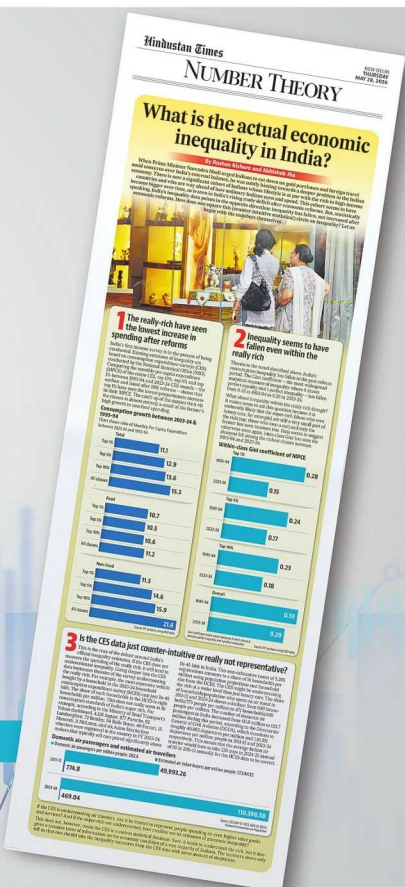
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Fear of losing Gen Z, poll math force BJP hand

Smriti Kak Ramachandran
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NEW DELHI: Prolonged deliberations within the government over the social and security ramifications of allowing the student protests over paper leaks to continue and the possible adverse electoral impact it might have for the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), which is already gearing for the next round of state elections, may have forced the resignation of Union education minister Dharmendra Pradhan on Saturday, said people aware of the details.

Another key reason was the fear of alienating a big demographic — young people, most specifically Gen Z — not limited by "geographical, faith and caste divisions", said one of the people in the BJP HT spoke to.

The protests over the irregularities in the conduct of the National Eligibility cum Entrance Test and other examinations were led by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), which was born out of online satire in May and began a sit-in strike at Jantar Mantar in June. The group — which elicited the support of students across India — had three main demands, with the resignation of Pradhan being the core one.

As negotiations between the CJP and the government hit a stalemate on the issue of the minister's resignation, Pradhan offered to step down, taking "moral responsibility", said the people cited above.

His party colleagues, who spoke on the condition of anonymity, said the protests snowballed into a major challenge for the BJP that is in power at the Centre and in 22 states and two Union territories with its allies.

"Since 2014, the BJP is known for riding out storms because not every issue, particularly political ones, merit resignation. The government firmly believes in fixing responsibility and making amends. Pradhan did exactly that by conducting a re-exam and the authorities moved swiftly to frame charges against the accused... but this protest was being misused by vested interests and political opponents who want to derail the government and its agenda," said a senior lawmaker.

This person said, "The government, starting with Prime Minister Narendra Modi, made efforts to alleviate the concerns of the students, but it became clear that there was no winning against the

Shah: Country, youth more important than any position

NEW DELHI: Union home minister Amit Shah on Saturday praised Dharmendra Pradhan's decision to resign from his post as the Union education minister, saying that it reflected the BJP's principle that the country, youth and students mattered more than any post.

In a post on X, Shah said, "For BJP workers, the country, our youth, and students are far more important than any position," adding that Pradhan's resignation "exemplifies" this BJP principle.

Lauding Pradhan, Shah highlighted several initiatives taken during his tenure as the education minister. He credited Pradhan for driving the implementation of the National Education Policy (NEP), promoting arrangements for examinations in regional mother tongues, expanding the Prime Minister's Schools for Rising India (PM SHRI) programme, supporting digital education and skill development, and strengthening industry-academia linkages.

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Amit Shah

"His efforts toward making the examination system more inclusive and student-centric have also been noteworthy," Shah wrote, adding that Pradhan's term demonstrated his commitment to the government's broader goal of making India a developed nation.

He wrote that Prime Minister Narendra Modi's government respected the sentiments of the country's youth and was committed to implementing the necessary reforms against paper leaks. "The decisions taken by Modi ji to ensure strict punishment for those guilty of paper leaks are commendable. I am fully confident that these steps will ensure complete justice for the students who succeeded in the NEET exam," he posted.

Shah has over time pressed for reforms in the education sector, from curriculum to day to day functioning of the ministry," said a Sangh functionary.

On Friday, RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat reflected on the generational shift and said India had moved from an "era of obedience" to youth demanding answers based on "logic and reasoning."

Without mentioning the CJP or the protests, he said institutions and families have to address their questions, offer guidance, and dedicate time rather than trying to enforce rules and commands.

Another compelling reason for the government's climbdown was the fear that a student's movement had larger resonance on the ground.

Leaks, glitches, and clashes: A tenure of controversies

CUET DEBUT FAILURE
Tech server crashes, technical glitches, and repeated postponements plagued the standardised common admission gateway run by the National Testing Agency (NTA)

2024 NEET-UG leak
Allegations of paper leaks, grace marks anomalies, and irregularities in Bihar and elsewhere triggered nationwide protests. Supreme Court interventions, and a CBI probe. Eventually, NTA chief was removed.

2025 State autonomy clashes
Non-BJP states criticised UGC draft regulations on Vice-Chancellor appointments as an erosion of university independence and federal autonomy

UGC-NET crisis
Just a day after the UGC-NET exam was conducted on June 18, the Centre cancelled it after tip-off that the question papers were circulated on the Darknet (via Telegram and other platforms). Education minister Dharmendra Pradhan confirmed the breach, leading to a CBI probe.

2026 Jan: Supreme Court intervention
The Supreme Court stayed the UGC (Promotion of Equity in Higher Education Institutions) Regulations, 2026 because its narrow definition of caste discrimination excluded non-reserved categories from protection

May: NEET-UG cancellation
Affected 2.27 million candidates; the exam was cancelled nine days after being conducted due to fresh paper leaks, triggering a CBI probe and 13 arrests

May: CBSE OSM evaluation fiasco
The Class 12 On-Screen Marking (OSM) rollout failed due to blurred scans and incorrect mark entries, after 36 internal dry-run warnings were ignored

'Resigned to stop anti-national forces from exploiting protest'

Smriti Kak Ramachandran
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NEW DELHI: Union education minister Dharmendra Pradhan said his resignation on Saturday was not a matter of personal prestige, and that he had stepped down to stop what he called anti-national forces from exploiting the agitation over examination paper leaks.

In a message on social media, Pradhan said, "...the situation should not be exploited by anti-national forces. The unity of the nation must remain intact. The future of even a single student of India should not become entangled in legal complications. Our children should devote their time to studies and focus on building their careers. Keeping these considerations in mind, I have sent my resignation to the Prime Minister."

"It is not a matter of individual prestige for me," he wrote in the letter. He went on to say while the government was mak-

I deeply respect... the legitimate expectations of the youth of the country

DHARMENDRA PRADHAN, Former Union education minister

ing amends to hold fresh examinations and fix responsibility, "...individuals holding responsible positions tried to create obstacles in order to mislead many students... which caused me deep anguish." He named no one and did not elaborate.

Elsewhere in the note, he said he respects the legitimate expectations of the youth.

"I deeply respect the aspirations, sentiments, and legitimate expectations of the youth of India's younger generation has

been a moral commitment of all of us in our political and social lives," he said.

Much of the rest was a defence of his handling of the NEET-UG paper leak. The government took immediate cognisance of the irregularities in the examination held on May 3, handed the investigation to the Central Bureau of Investigation, cancelled the test and announced a date for a re-examination, he said.

"Along with this, it was decided that from next year onward, this examination will be conducted in CBT (Computer-Based Test) mode. During this period, our primary priority was to ensure the smooth conduct of the examination for more than two million students. For this, work was carried out under the 'whole of government approach'," Pradhan said.

State governments and district administrations had played an important role in conducting the fresh examination, he said.

LEADERS HAIL PRADHAN

Shri @dpradhanbjp's tenure as Union Minister has been marked by a steadfast commitment to transforming India into developed nation. His contribution to public service has been inclusive, future-ready, and aligned with the aspirations of a New India.

—Rajnath Singh, Defence minister

Leading such a critical sector demands immense perseverance & he embraced it with courage & clear vision. Dharmendra ji, thank you for your relentless service, your commitment to reforms & your contribution to building a stronger India. I wish you the very best as you continue to serve the nation with the same conviction & sincerity!

—Kiren Rijiju, Parliamentary affairs minister

As Union Education Minister, Shri Dharmendra Pradhan Ji played a pivotal role in reaping India's education landscape and successfully implementing the landmark National Education Policy (NEP 2020), among other initiatives.

—Nitin Nabin, BJP national president



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New paper leak bill prescribes 2-month window for probes

Saubhadra Chatterji
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NEW DELHI: A new stringent bill against examination paper leak aims for stricter punishment, hikes the minimum jail term and quantum of fines, and promises speedy trials by setting up fast-track courts that are mandated to finish trials within three months from the filing of the chargesheet.

Overhauling the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024, the government will introduce on Monday a series of amendments promised by Prime Minister Narendra Modi in the wake of surging protests by students. The bill allows for the formation of a special task force, time-bound probe, and daily proceedings during trial.

In recent years, there have been some incidents of question paper leakages and malpractices in examinations conducted by public examination authorities, which tend to affect the transparency and fairness of the public examinations system. Hence, in order to further strengthen the fairness, to enhance the credibility of the public examinations system and to ensure time bound investigations of offences under the said act, it is necessary to make amendments in the said Act," said the statement of objects of the bill, a copy of which HT has seen.

According to the proposed law, anyone resorting to "unfair means and offences", shall be punished with imprisonment for a term not less than "five years but which may extend up to ten years and with fine up to fifty lakh rupees". Similarly, the service provider can be punished with a fine of ₹5 crore and the proportionate cost of examination shall also be recovered from the service provider, who will be barred from any responsibility for a public examination for eight years.

In the current bill, the jail term for unfair means and offences was three to five years with ₹10 lakh fine. Similarly, service pro-

OVERHAULING THE PUBLIC EXAMINATIONS (PREVENTION OF UNFAIR MEANS) ACT, 2024, THE GOVT WILL INTRODUCE ON MONDAY A SERIES OF AMENDMENTS

viders' fine was one crore with a ban for four years.

The proposed legislation increased the minimum jail term to five years from three, and the fine to ₹5 crore from ₹2 crore for any director, senior management or persons in-charge of the service provider firm found guilty during the investigation.

For organised crime resulting in paper leaks, a person or a group of persons shall be punished with a minimum jail term of seven years which may extend to 10 years with a fine of ₹10 crore.

Union minister for the department of personnel and training Jitendra Singh, who is also the government interlocutor with student protesters along with Union health minister JP Nadda, is set to introduce the bill in the Lok Sabha on Monday.

The proposed bill inserts two new sections—12A and 12B—for speedy probe and trials. The current bill stipulated investigation by federal agencies. The new bill allows the government to set up a special task force for the same purpose. The new sections say a central investigating agency or special investigation team shall complete the probe "within a period of two months from the date of a reference made to it by the central government."

Making specific provisions for the fast track courts, the bill stated, "For the purposes of providing a speedy trial on day-to-day basis, every state government and Union territory administration shall, in consultation with

the chief justice of the concerned high court, by notification, designate a court of session, to be a special fast track court to try offences under this act."

It also imposes strict timelines for trial.

"In every trial of an offence under this act, the proceedings shall be continued on a day-to-day basis, until all the witnesses in attendance have been examined, unless the special fast track court, for reasons to be recorded in writing, finds that adjournment of the same beyond the following day is necessary: Provided that such trial shall be completed within a period of three months from the date of filing of the chargesheet," the provisions of the new legislation said.

The bill said that an "appeal shall lie from any judgment, sentence or order, not being an interlocutory order, of a special fast track court to the high court".

"Every appeal under sub-section (1) shall be heard by a bench of two judges of the high court and shall, as far as possible, be disposed of within a period of three months from the date of admission of the appeal," it added.

"Except as aforesaid, no appeal or revision shall lie to any court from any judgment, sentence or order including an interlocutory order of a special fast track court" and "an appeal shall lie to the high court against an order of the special fast track court granting or refusing bail."

The bill also tightened provisions for appeals. "Every appeal under this section shall be preferred within a period of thirty days from the date of the judgment, sentence or order appealed from. Provided that the high court may entertain an appeal after the expiry of the said period of thirty days if it is satisfied that the appellant had sufficient cause for not preferring the appeal within the period of thirty days: Provided further that no appeal shall be entertained after the expiry of the period of ninety days," it said.

Protesters mark victory



(Clockwise from left) Protesters hold placards in Mumbai; a woman carries a portrait of Dr BR Ambedkar in Nagpur; and students perform in Amritsar as part of nationwide celebrations over the resignation of Union education minister Dharmendra Pradhan on Saturday. AP/PTV/ANI



Use of pellet guns to be flashpoint in Parl

Saubhadra Chatterji
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Opposition parties plan to turn the heat on Union home minister Amit Shah for the use of pellet guns and the brutal thrashing of the students by the security forces, following the resignation of Union education minister Dharmendra Pradhan, people familiar with the matter said.

This could well mean that the second week of the monsoon session is as unproductive as the first. Opposition parties will meet on Monday to decide the scope of their participation in the Parliament proceedings. After Pradhan's resignation, a section of the Opposition is keen to corner the government over the alleged theft of donations at the Ram Mandir.

But many to press the advantage by continuing to focus on paper leaks and the protest. Leader of the Opposition Rahul Gandhi told media at 10, Janpath on Saturday, "The first thing is that we hold Mr. Amit Shah directly responsible for the violence that has taken place against our students. He authorised the shooting of our students; he authorised the

Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation is a huge step towards reshaping our education system

RAHUL GANDHI,
Lok Sabha Leader of Opposition

use of lethal weapons, pellet guns on our students. So, that, for us, is a fundamental issue. We will not accept our own forces shooting the future of India. So, that is going to be a major issue in Parliament."

Despite denials, there is now growing evidence that the RAF may have used pellet guns while clashing with protesters during Monday's march to Parliament.

According to functionaries aware of the details, senior Opposition leaders discussed the developments and the agenda for the week ahead over phone on Saturday but it is not clear if Parliament will run smoothly from Monday.

After such a massive struggle, govt's arrogance ultimately had to bow before the people

ARVIND KEJRIWAL,
AAP national convener

Trinamool Congress' Rajya Sabha leader Derek O'Brien claimed that the Opposition might oppose the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill, the tougher anti-paper leak law the government wants to legislate. "The government wants to divert attention with this bill. We will oppose it," he said.

O'Brien too stressed on the need to focus on the protests. "We have all agreed to seek accountability from Amit Shah. Students were brutally beaten up in Delhi. Pellet guns were fired. Shah can't escape his accountability."

Dear children, This win belongs to you. We salute your courage, determination and persistence

DIMPLE YADAV,
Samajwadi Party Lok Sabha MP

CPI(M) lawmaker John Brittas echoed that sentiment: "The resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan has certainly created an ecosystem in which we can possibly participate in the debate on the bill. But resignation was not the only issue for us. The issue of the cops who brutally thrashed students and the issue of compensation are unresolved."

When asked if the Opposition will participate in the discussion and support the bill, Gandhi told reporters that the Congress will discuss this with other opposition parties and "make decisions based on the consensus that emerges."

WANGCHUK HAILS STUDENT-LED STR FOR RESIGNATION

NEW DELHI: Activist Sonam Wangchuk on Saturday described education minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation as "a victory of democracy", and credited the nationwide student-led agitation for the outcome.

Calling it "a victory of peace, patience and perseverance", he congratulated the Cockroach Janata Party, Gen Z and citizens for participating in the stir over NEET paper leak. "Congratulations CJP, Gen Z of the nation and thank you all citizens for shedding fear and the fear of fear and rising up from every corner of the nation."

His wife, Gitanjali Argonsa, said the youth in India, unlike their counterparts across the world, stood against "injustice without burning the country down."

"If anyone has shown what it means for India to be a Vishwaguru, it is our Gen Z. They have lived Sanatan Dharma, not preached it...," she wrote on X. **HTC**

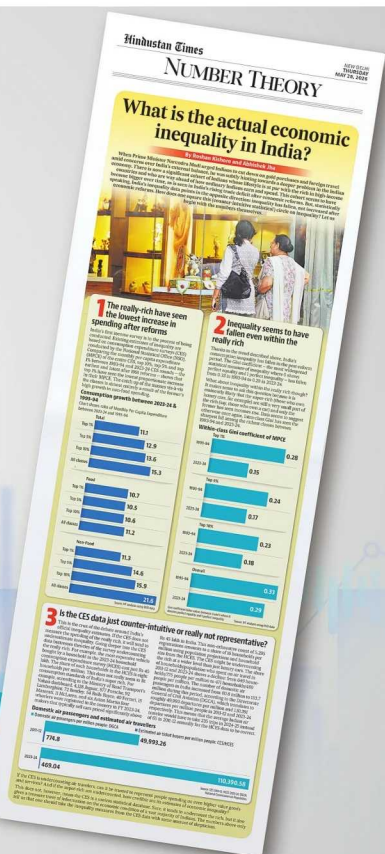
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Assam flood toll surges to 62 this yr; PM takes stock

HTC and agencies
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SILCHAR: The flood situation in Assam remained grim on Saturday, with the toll from rain-related incidents reaching 62 and the waters affecting 705,000 people across nine districts, according to officials familiar with the matter, even as water levels started to recede in some parts.

According to Assam State Disaster Management Authority (ASDMA) bulletin on Friday night, 14 people died across nine districts in the last 24 hours.



Partially submerged cars in flood-hit Sivasagar on Saturday, surges

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday sought an update from chief minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on the relief and rescue operations that continue across the flood-hit districts. "He sought an update on the extent of the devastation, the ongoing relief operations and the challenges we are confronting on the ground. I briefed him on the measures being undertaken by the State Government and our efforts to reach out to every affected family," Sarma wrote on X.

Expressing his deep condolences over the loss of lives and property, the Hon'ble Prime Minister assured the people of Assam that this calamity is being

accorded the highest priority and the Government of India will extend every possible support to aid our relief, rehabilitation and rebuilding efforts," Sarma added.

The Indian Army and the Indian Air Force (IAF) are also assisting the state government in the relief operations.

According to ASDMA, seven people died in Charaideo on Friday while six deaths were reported from Sivasagar and one in Jorhat. Till Thursday, 21 deaths had been reported in Sivasagar alone and with six more, the toll in the district reached 27. ASDMA said that one person is missing.

Meanwhile, two workers died, and four were injured after a landslide hit them while clearing debris from a stretch of road that was brought in by a previous landslide in Sikkim's Namchi district on Saturday afternoon, police said. Six workers were engaged in clearing the debris that had blocked the road connecting Sada and Phantam villages when a fresh landslide hit the worksite, burying the workers under debris.

In Gujarat, 35 rain-related deaths have been reported in the past two days, officials said on Saturday, even as the downpour in the state ceased. Twenty-nine of these deaths have taken place

in Valsad and Navsari, two of the worst affected districts, with over 7,000 people rescued in the last few days, they added.

"A total of 35 rain-related deaths have been reported so far in the state in the last two days as bodies washed away in flood waters were recovered and missing persons were accounted for after the rain stopped and rescue operations concluded," Relief Commissioner Gaurang Makwana said.

Rain continued to lash several parts of Kashmir for the fifth consecutive day on Saturday. However, the officials said the flood threat has eased as the levels in most water bodies were decreasing.

In Maharashtra, the Palghar district administration has stepped up the distribution of financial assistance and relief packages to flood-affected families during the first week of this month, which left 20 people dead, officials said.

An ex gratia of ₹4 lakh per family was sanctioned for each eligible victim, and financial aid totalling ₹32 lakh has already been disbursed to eight families, it said. The process to release the money to the remaining families is underway, said officials.

5 KILLED AFTER SPEEDING CAR PLUNGES INTO RESERVOIR IN M.P.

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RAGGARH: Five men were killed after their speeding car veered off the road and plunged into a roadside dam in Madhya Pradesh's Raigarh district on Saturday, police said.

The accident occurred near Bilkhed junction under the Khujner police station limits, about 30 km from the Raigarh district headquarters. The car was on its way from Pachore towards Khujner. SHO Ravi Thakur told PTI over the phone.

The victims were residents of Aranya village in neighbouring Shajapur district, he added.

Police, assisted by residents and the administration, launched a rescue operation and retrieved the submerged vehicle from the dam. All five occupants were found dead at the scene, Thakur said.

Police have launched an investigation to ascertain the exact cause of the accident, he added.

UP govt reconstitutes SIT in Ram temple fund theft case

HT Correspondent
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The new SIT will comprise inspector general Kiran S as its chairperson.

LUCKNOW: The Uttar Pradesh government has reconstituted the Special Investigation Team (SIT) probing the alleged theft of cash donations at the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Temple in Ayodhya, appointing inspector general (Lucknow range) Kiran S to head the fresh three-member panel. In compliance with the directions issued by the Supreme Court.

The top court had on July 20 asked the Uttar Pradesh government to consider placing the ongoing police investigation under the supervision of the same three-member SIT that had first uncovered prima facie evidence of the alleged theft.

According to people familiar with the matter, the new SIT will

comprise Kiran S as its chairperson, while DIG (Ayodhya) Sonam Barma and SSP (Ayodhya) Gaurav Grover will serve as members. Though the constitution of the new panel has been agreed upon by the state authorities, an official notification confirming the appointments was yet to be issued till the filing of this report.

The reconstituted SIT replaces

the earlier panel headed by Lucknow divisional commissioner Vijay Vishwas Pant, an IAS officer. Kiran S was also a member of the previous SIT and has now been entrusted with leading the criminal investigation.

People familiar with the matter said the newly constituted SIT is expected to submit its first progress report before the apex court on July 27.

The initial SIT was formed on June 13 at the request of the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust. It submitted its nine-page preliminary report on June 23, following which Ayodhya police registered an FIR against eight people allegedly involved in siphoning off donations during the counting process. All eight accused have since been arrested.

India, US working to conclude trade agreement early: Govt

HT Correspondent
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AN ESTIMATED 45% OF INDIA'S EXPORTS TO THE US REMAIN OUTSIDE THE ADDITIONAL 10% DUTY'S PURVIEW, SAID THE GOVT

NEW DELHI: India's engagements with the US Trade Representative (USTR) helped secure a lower tariff for Indian goods, the commerce ministry said on Saturday, adding that both nations were seeking an "early conclusion" of the planned bilateral trade agreement.

The statement followed the imposition of 10% additional tariffs on goods from India on Friday under Section 301 of the US Trade Act, 1974. "USTR has imposed an additional 10% ad valorem duty on imports from India. This is a reduction from the 12.5% duty initially proposed on 2nd June 2026," said a statement from the ministry.

The ministry said the Centre engaged closely with the USTR "through detailed written submissions and in-person consultations, including participation in public hearings."

"As a result of these sustained efforts, India has been placed in the lower tier of additional tariffs under the final measures, providing a relative advantage to Indian exports in key sectors," it

Section 232 duties are applicable broadly to all countries with limited exceptions.

On account of these exemptions, an estimated 45% of India's exports to the US remain outside the purview of the additional 10% duty.

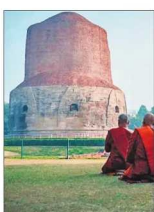
For the remaining 55%, India's tariff incidence is comparatively lower than that for most other economies covered, said the statement.

"The textile specific mechanism referenced in the final measures is yet to be established and operationalised. India continues to engage with the US on this matter as part of the ongoing negotiations for the India-US Bilateral Trade Agreement," the statement said, referring to the probable textile and apparel tariff-rate quota (TRQ) for Bangladesh, Cambodia, Indonesia, and Malaysia, all of which use US-origin cotton and fiber.

The statement concluded by reiterating the government's commitment towards the India-US Bilateral Trade Agreement, "as announced on 2nd February 2026 and in accordance with the Joint Statement issued on 7th February 2026."

{ PM LAUDS 'PROUD MOMENT' } UNESCO LIST

Sarnath now India's 45th World Heritage site



UNESCO described Sarnath as one of four principal Buddhist pilgrimage sites identified by the Buddha himself.

HT Correspondent
letters@hindustantimes.com

VARANASI: Twenty-eight years after entering UNESCO's Tentative List, Sarnath in Uttar Pradesh has made it on the UNESCO World Heritage List.

The site, where Gautama Buddha is believed to have delivered his first sermon after attaining enlightenment, has now become Uttar Pradesh's fourth and India's 45th World Heritage site.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi took to X to hail the designation. "A proud moment for every Indian! Delighted that Sarnath in Uttar Pradesh has been inscribed on the UNESCO World Heritage List," he said.

"This recognition celebrates India's profound civilisational and spiritual heritage. It will also inspire more people across the world to come to Sarnath and connect with the ideals of Lord Buddha," added the PM.

The move was announced during the 48th Session of the World Heritage Committee. UNESCO described the site as one of four principal Buddhist pilgrimage sites identified by the Buddha himself. "After flourishing as a major Buddhist centre, Sarnath declined in the 12th century CE and fell into obscurity until its rediscovery in the 18th century," its website said.

Union culture minister Gajendra Singh Shekhawat also took to X on a jubilant note. "Sarnath

reflects the profound spiritual and philosophical contributions of Indian civilisation to humanity."

State culture minister Jaiveer Singh said the achievement reflected Uttar Pradesh's effort to bring the many strands of its civilisational heritage into national and international focus.

Conservation architect Abha Narain Lamba, who prepared Sarnath's nomination, said it rested upon something larger than the significance of individual monuments. "Sarnath brings together the place of the First Sermon, the beginnings of the Buddhist architectural forms and a pilgrimage tradition spanning nearly 2,500 years," she said.

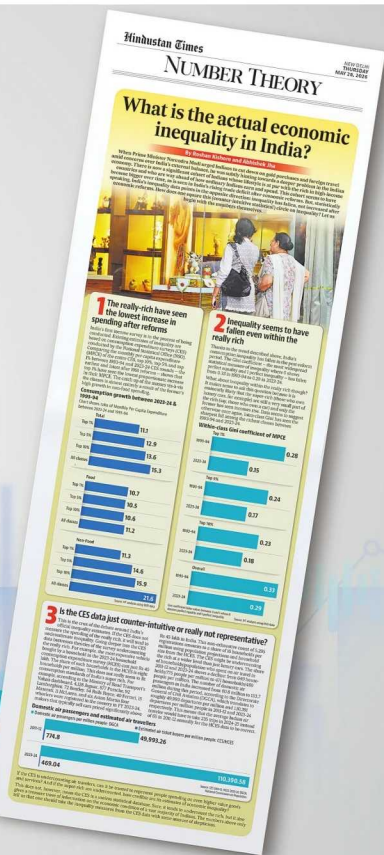
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Car crashes into drain near Vasant Kunj, 20-yr-old killed

Hemani Bhandari
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NEW DELHI: A 20-year-old student died after the car he was driving allegedly skidded off a slippery stretch, crashed through a boundary structure along a Delhi Development Authority (DDA) drain and overturned near the Nangal Dewat red light in southwest Delhi's Vasant Kunj on Friday morning, police said.

According to police, the deceased was identified as Yashvendra Singh, pursuing higher education in the United States and son of an Indian Army officer. He was residing in the Delhi Cantonment area. A female friend, who was travelling with him in her car, survived the crash, police added.

Investigators said that a PCR call regarding the accident was received at Vasant Kunj South police station around 6am on Friday. "When officers reached the spot, they found the vehicle overturned inside a DDA drain near the Nangal Dewat red light," an officer said.

Preliminary investigation revealed that Singh and his friend, both students at the same institution in the US, were heading from another friend's house



The car near the drain that it plunged into after careening out of control in southwest Delhi on Friday.

RAJ RAHIM PHOTO

In Vasant Kunj towards the woman's residence in the same locality when the accident occurred. Police said that while negotiating a sharp turn near the traffic signal, Singh allegedly lost control of the vehicle due to the slippery road surface. "The car veered off the carriageway, plunged into the DDA drain and overturned," the officer said. Both occupants sustained injuries and were taken for treatment. Singh later succumbed to his injuries, police said.

long break," said a friend who did not wish to be identified.

Responding to the incident, the DDA said a site inspection was carried out by its field staff on Friday following the accident.

"Based on enquiries made with the police personnel, it was learnt that the car was allegedly travelling at high speed, following which it skidded and overturned," the DDA said in a statement. The authority said the vehicle "subsequently hit a nearby tree, damaged a portion of the toe wall along the nallah, and broke the concrete covers."

Friends alleged that if the drain had been covered, their friend would have survived. "What's the point of raising complaints here? Nothing happens," a friend said. Residents' Welfare Association (RWA) president of Nangal Dewat, Pradeep Sehrawat, said, "This is a drain of death. Some tankers come at night and dump kerosene here. We have written to the DDA multiple times to cover it but our requests fall on deaf ears."

The DDA, in a statement, said, "It is clarified that a toe wall is already provided along the nallah. A proposal to construct an RCC box drain at the location is already under process and at an advanced stage.

GREATER NOIDA: BOY DROWNS IN FLOODED PIT DUG BY AUTHORITY

GREATER NOIDA: A six-year-old boy drowned in a 10-foot-deep water pit dug by the Greater Noida authority inside Kaladham Society residential housing in Knowledge Park-2 on Saturday evening, police officers said. A video of the spot also went viral, in which a man pointed out that there was no barricading and no safety measures.

Ravi Shankar Nim, deputy commissioner of police, Greater Noida, said, "It is believed that the Greater Noida authority awarded a contract for a borewell to address the society's water crisis. However, the investigation is underway to identify the nature of the work and any lapses during its execution. A case will be registered after the investigation."

Acknowledging the lack of safety measures, an officer with the Greater Noida authority, on condition of anonymity, told HT, "The work was related to borewell and strict action will be taken against responsible person on Sunday."

The boy left home to play with a friend on Saturday evening, when he fell into the pit located around 200-300 metres from his home, officers said. His family members and others rescued the child and rushed him to a hospital, but he was declared dead on arrival.

ANUR SINGH

HT TWTW THE WEEK THAT WAS

Quick! Take the quiz to catch up with the news of the week

From out of this world to the top of the world; from a 27-year-old record, to a two-year lull; from delivery apps to a protest site.... These Qs are waiting to be answered



This star shuttler is the first Indian to win the Japan Open

Scientists are unhappy at India's top scientific and research organisations. Meanwhile, start-ups in the same field — Pixxel, Skyroot, Agnikul Cosmos and Bellatrix — are hiring aggressively. Which skyrocketing institute is facing brain drain?

Nolan recently wore a tie bearing which Gujarati craft?

Christopher Nolan wore a tie. It was a block-printed silk one, resistance dyed with geometric patterns of Indigo and madder. It spotlighted a centuries-old handicraft and textile tradition rooted in Kutch, Gujarat, and Sindh, Pakistan. Which craft?

Gus crushed the world record like he would crush his prey's skull, with a bite-force of 8,000 pounds, when he was auctioned for \$50.1 million. He's 12-and-a-half feet tall. He's 67 million years old and has more than 60% of his bones. Who is Gus?

She's back! After two years fraught with injury and an early Olympics exit, this star shuttler just became the first Indian to win the Japan Open. She says a conversation with Virat Kohli led her to rediscover the joy of the game. Who is she?

Brown-paper bags of food showed up. Delivery services brought in pizzas, burgers, medicines and water bottles. The receiver: Any one of the thousands gathered to protest against India's leaky education system. Give the Delhi delivery address.

Breakbone fever is carried by the Aedes mosquito. It infects more than two lakh Indians every year. India has finally approved a vaccine, QDENGA, already greenlit in the EU and UK. Two doses, three months apart. Which infection will it control?

Josh Kerr is the fastest man to run 1,609 km, clocking 3:42:66, breaking a 27-year record. The distance — equal to 5,280 English feet — is a unit of length in the US. Not related to the nautical, Roman or Italian units. What distance did Kerr run?

Tokyo started a hairy debate! The government wants salarymen to ditch trousers in the heat and wear these instead. It's prompted women to use the term Sunehara or embarrassment caused by having or viewing leg hair. What clothing frees the knees?

Some insects are fit for human consumption in S Korea. One that carries many times its own body weight is not. A top restaurant used it. Diners called it adventurous. Prosecutors called it illegal. The restaurateur faces jail time. Which insect?

The world's highest biennale takes place at 5,000 metres above sea level. It's called sá, or soil in the local language. It will turn the Leh-Kargil corridor into an open-air arts festival next month. In which union territory does it fall?

Answers on page 09

{ GURUGRAM } AROUND 30 SHELL COMPANIES GENERATED FAKE INVOICES

₹200-cr input tax credit fraud busted; 4 held

Leena Dhankhar
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GURUGRAM: The anti-evasion wing of the Central Goods and Services Tax (CGST) Commissionerate, Gurugram, on Saturday said it has unearthed a ₹200-crore input tax credit fraud and arrested four people, including two co-founders of a Gurugram-based auto service startup and two chartered accountants. The suspects were produced before the duty magistrate and sent to 14 days of judicial custody.

According to CGST officials, the fraud was executed through a network of nearly 30 shell

companies that allegedly generated fake invoices without actual supply of goods or payment of GST. These invoices were then used to fraudulently claim input tax credit, causing an estimated loss of around ₹200 crore to the national exchequer.

"The investigation revealed a well-planned and sophisticated network of shell companies used solely for invoice routing and artificial layering of transactions. There was billing on paper, but neither was tax deposited with the government nor was there any actual movement of goods," a CGST Gurugram spokesperson said.

The investigation started based on intelligence received from the Customs, with the probe taking six to eight months, as investigators tracked financial transactions, analysed company records and uncovered multiple layers of fictitious entities allegedly created to conceal the movement of funds.

Officials said the two main accused are former founding directors of an on-demand auto, mobile service and battery assistance startup established in 2016-17. According to investigators, the alleged fraud began after 2021, as they started creating fake invoices and shell ent-

ities to fraudulently avail of tax benefits. "The suspect had professional expertise. Two chartered accountants allegedly played a key role in designing and operating the fraudulent network," the spokesperson said.

Investigators said the suspects were served summons and asked to appear before CGST officials on Saturday, following which they were questioned and arrested. "During questioning, we confronted them with documentary evidence and digital records. Based on the material available during the investigation, they confessed and were arrested under the provisions of

the CGST Act," an assistant commissioner, CGST Gurugram, who did not wish to be named, said. Officials said no recovery has been made so far, and the investigation is continuing to identify additional beneficiaries, trace financial transactions and determine whether more entities or individuals were involved.

Another senior official said investigators were also examining whether the suspects intended to use the artificially inflated financial records to strengthen the company's valuation ahead of a proposed initial public offering (IPO) and a possible stake sale.



She's back! After two years fraught with injury and an early Olympics exit, this star shuttler just became the first Indian to win the Japan Open. She says a conversation with Virat Kohli led her to rediscover the joy of the game. Who is she?

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PRADHAN RESIGNS

Joint press conference with Nadda and Singh.
"As the government accepted all our demands after 36 days of protests, we appeal to everyone to peacefully withdraw from protest sites and go home," Ranka said.

Das said they have shared a draft of the demands with the government and the government will share a written guarantee by Tuesday. There was no word on the demand for an apology from the government over clashes on July 20.

Nadda said the CJP representatives came to the meeting with a written draft on cases filed during the July 20 agitation. Delhi Police have filed at least 15 FIRs in connection with the protest when tens of thousands of young people broke barricades, braved tear gas shells and batons to march to Parliament.

Nadda said the government also discussed demands of no retaliatory measures against agitators, compensation for the families of NEET aspirants who died, and a five-point CJP charter.

"After the discussion, the first point was that no action should be taken and no FIRs should be filed. If any FIRs have already been registered, whether by the Delhi Police or in BJP-ruled states, it will be withdrawn," Nadda said, adding that the government agreed to give 'honourable compensation within the rules' to the families of NEET suicide victims.

"All our demands have been accepted by the government," Das said. Nadda said the government will provide to CJP copies of FIRs registered.

The announcements drew a dramatic denouement to the sweeping protests that were birthed by a controversial comment by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant describing unemployed people and dubious degree holders earlier this year.

"I thank CJI Surya Kant ji for calling us cockroaches. If you had not called us cockroaches, the youth would not have been on the roads," Dipke said at Jantar Mantar to cheers.

The CJP first garnered millions of followers on social media before launching an indefinite sit-in protest on June 20 demanding the resignation of Pradhan over repeated question paper leaks—including one earlier this year. After days of

tepid crowds, the movement was galvanised by the hunger strike and forcible removal of activist Sonam Wangchuk last week.

Crowds swelled through the weekend and by Monday morning, columns of people—many of them students, first-time agitators and young professionals—had defied a steady drizzle and police barricading to join what became the largest street protests in Prime Minister Narendra Modi's third term.

Over 100 protesters and 129 security personnel were injured. One protester remains in the ICU.

Over the past week, crowds swelled and spilled beyond the confines of Jantar Mantar as thousands of young people poured into central Delhi, despite the longest spells of internet shutdown and metro station closure in Delhi, scores of barricades that sparked traffic snarls across the capital, and controversial police detention from roads over protesters carrying posters or pepper spray.

Tensions sporadically flared at the site, most dramatically on Wednesday night when clashes between protesters and police led to injuries to five agitators and five police personnel.

As the storm of Gen Z protesters grew, the government's efforts to break the impasse kicked into overdrive. Nadda and Singh convinced Wangchuk to break his fast, Modi made a rare personal appeal to young people on Instagram and promised a stringent new bill—which will come before Parliament on Monday—to tackle paper leaks, and the National Testing Agency fired top officials.

The police continues to be under fire over allegations of excess force used to scatter crowds on July 20: the Supreme Court is set to hear two appeals on Monday even as four people have alleged that the security forces used pellet guns on them—an unprecedented occurrence in the Capital.

But on Saturday afternoon, as an avalanche of people—many of them school students, many of them first-time protesters who had never stepped outside campuses before, many who travelled a night or more to be there—thronged Jantar Mantar, the jubilation around their achievement had washed away the bitterness. "Everyone thought we were lazy, we don't know anything beyond Instagram or our phones," said Nikita Joshi, 19.

"Today, our generation raised its voice."

FROM PAGE 1

SPAIN, FRANCE FIRES

In the Spanish town of Brunete, west of Madrid, mayor Mar Nicolas told AFP she was "very worried".

"Every year there are fires, but this one has been tremendous," she said. "It is a catastrophe."

A separate wildfire near the eastern Spanish city of Valencia killed one person before firefighters brought it under control.

Overstretched firefighters in Spain and France battling around the clock for days have been unable to contain the infernos, though authorities in both countries suggested the intensity of some of the blazes had notched down.

Two French firefighters died earlier this week near Bordeaux.

French Interior Minister Laurent Nunez said the blaze in the Gironde region where Bordeaux is located was less intense and no longer a "connective" type of fire that self-fuels through rising currents.

Officials in Madrid also said the fires had advanced little overnight and decreased in intensity. But the battles were far from won.

The threat in Gironde "remains serious," said top regional official Sophie Brocas.

Spain's Sanchez warned: "We are going to have some complex hours ahead."

Jacqueline Villafranca, a 38-year-old who evacuated to Madrid on Friday, said that when smoke filled her village of Navagamella "I thought everything was going to burn, the house and everything."

"Here you can breathe normally—yesterday it was unbearable," she said, sitting in a gymnasium-turned-shelter.

The fires in Spain and France advanced quickly because of tinderbox conditions worsened by successive heatwaves in the two countries since May.

Scientists say global warming is increasing droughts and causing weather emergencies to become more extreme and more frequent.

Europe is the fastest-warming continent due to climate change.

Both countries were receiving EU help in the form of firefighting aircraft from other European countries.

France has deployed 1,500 soldiers to help firefighters near Bordeaux, and on Saturday an A400M military transport aircraft modified to release up to 20 tonnes of fire retardant joined the fleet of smaller planes already dousing flames.

The head of the Paris fire brigade told AFP that 100 firefighters from the French capital had been deployed to the southwest, adding

to 45 firefighters and six vehicles already sent there.

Emergency shelters were set up in schools and gymnasiums in southwestern France for tourists and residents left wondering what they would return to.

Nuala Kelly, a 75-year-old Irish tourist, said she had never seen anything like this.

"Never, never, never, never, and I've travelled all over the world and been in all sorts of situations," she told AFP at Bordeaux's vast exhibition centre now housing thousands of people.

Oliver Stewart, a 38-year-old Frenchman who had to leave the village of Merignac with his wife and young children, said the children were "the most stressed".

"They think the fire is going to burn down the house, but we're coping," he said.

Sunday's final stage of the Tour de France road cycling race has been shortened after the interior ministry said it would need to redeploy officers mobilised for race security to the fires instead.

The massive smoke clouds thrown up by the French and Spanish fires were starting to connect in the atmosphere, according to satellite images from Spain's Aemet weather agency.

Fires currently raging across France have burned nearly 98,000 hectares — a "historic record", Nunez said.

In the southwest alone, the flames have consumed more than 32,000 hectares — three times the surface area of Paris — and destroyed at least 100 buildings, authorities said.

French President Emmanuel Macron said the country "will rebuild".

The blazes west of Madrid have burned up to 25,000 hectares, according to Spain's interior ministry. Two of the three major wildfires there have merged into one, and are threatening to join up to form a massive inferno just kilometres from the capital.

THE CROSSWORDS

CRYPTIC CLUES

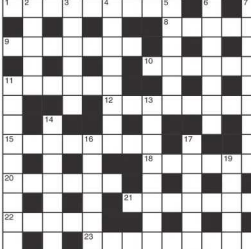
- ACROSS
1 She will shortly arrive for seafood (9)
8 Architectural highlight (5)
9 A number leave one country for another (7)
10 Note article cannot be reduced (6)
11 It's old perhaps and not easily moved (6)
12 Intrude by chance or accident (8)
15 He had a model mother (8)
16 Put in charge again (6)
20 Do they keep to the beaten track? (6)
21 Fish and turtle photographer? (7)
22 Many pieces of wood made to last? (5)
23 Shop early for capers (9)

DOWN

- 2 A hunt for the den of criminals (5)
3 Yet all has been changed recently (6)
4 Just treatment for honest card-players (4)
15 He is as cold as a chameleon (6)
16 Excavate almost everything with the fingers (7)
17 Straight thinking on what deconstructs do (5,4)
18 Indicate where to find a tourist attraction (9)
19 Dog raves after fruit (8)
20 Unmarried woman I took on for a job? (7)
21 Songster's throat infection (6)
22 Do wrong in bringing up students (4,2)
23 Region holding northern sports venue (5)

PUZZLE 17547

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QUICK CLUES

ACROSS

- 1 Wealth (9)
2 Defect (5)
3 Fippancy (6)
4 Pass completely round (8)
5 Eversion (6)
6 Be enough (7)
7 Painting of inanimate objects (5,4)
8 Decisive (8)
9 Clearly expressive (8)
10 Make possible (6)
11 Stand to reason (4,5)
12 Country's domestic affairs (8)
13 Temporary stay (7)
14 Not accustomed (6)
15 Leave stranded (6)
16 Sensational (5)

DOWN

- 2 Judicial proceedings (5)
3 Fippancy (6)
4 Pass completely round (8)
5 Eversion (6)
6 Be enough (7)
7 Painting of inanimate objects (5,4)
8 Decisive (8)
9 Clearly expressive (8)
10 Make possible (6)
11 Stand to reason (4,5)
12 Country's domestic affairs (8)
13 Temporary stay (7)
14 Not accustomed (6)
15 Leave stranded (6)
16 Sensational (5)

FRIDAY'S SOLUTIONS (17546)

CRYPTIC
1. DEPTHEITY
2. ATLAS
3. GOUTE
4. BOSTONIAN
5. COPIER
6. ENTIRE
7. NARRATIVE
8. RECHUTE
9. SOGGIER
10. BLOCKHOUSE
11. A HATE
12. EMBLE
13. GLOU
14. ION
15. SIRON
16. ENTIER
17. GAIROTTE

QUICK
1. CHAUCIER
2. CLOVER
3. P
4. P
5. P
6. P
7. P
8. P
9. P
10. P
11. P
12. P
13. P
14. P
15. P
16. P
17. P
18. P
19. P
20. P
21. P
22. P
23. P

ANSWERS

1. Isro
2. Ajrakh
3. A T-Rex
4. PV Sindhu
5. Jantar Mantar
6. Dengue
7. A mile
8. Shorts
9. Ants
10. Ladakh

WEATHER

TEMPERATURE - HIGH - LOW

SUNDAY	MONDAY	TUESDAY
Generally cloudy sky with moderate rain	Generally cloudy sky with light rain	Generally cloudy sky with light rain
30°C 20°C	30°C 21°C	30°C 21°C

ALMANAC

Today is 26 July 2026
15 Safar 1448
26 July 2026
Safar 1448
Sunset: Sunday at 18:48 hrs
Moonrise: Sunday at 18:25 hrs
Moonset: Monday at 05:52 hrs

TEMPERATURE IN METROS

Delhi	34°C 25°C
Mumbai	29°C 38°C
Kolkata	30°C 26°C
Chennai	38°C 28°C
Bengaluru	30°C 20°C

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{ FROM PAGE 1 }

HOUTHIS HIT SAUDI

sites aimed at oil installations were intercepted by a U.S.-made Patriot battery operated in Saudi Arabia by the Greek military under an agreement with Riyadh, Greek security sources said.

Yanbu is Saudi Arabia's main Red Sea oil port, where millions of barrels a day are loaded, and has become the main route out for Saudi oil skirting the Strait of Hormuz, which has been blockaded by Iran. Jizan, on the Red Sea close to the Yemeni border, is the site of a refinery with a capacity of 400,000 barrels per day.

In Yemen, the air force of the Saudi-backed, internationally recognised government, which has opposed the Houthis for more than a decade, struck Houthi missile and drone launch sites and arms depots in the Marib and al-Jawf provinces, Yemeni officials said.

Earlier, the Saudi-led military alliance said it had bombed Houthi military positions on Friday in the Red Sea port of Hodeidah.

The Yemeni officials said both sides in Yemen's civil war were mobilising forces along the front.

Saudi Arabia has led an Arab coalition battling against the Houthis for more than a decade since the Iran-aligned fighters captured Yemen's capital, Sanaa.

The Yemeni civil war, during which hundreds of thousands of people died from fighting and famine, has been paused under a ceasefire since 2022. But that

truce broke down this month, with the Houthis effectively joining the wider war their Iranian allies have waged since being attacked by the U.S. and Israel.

The Houthis have declared a naval blockade of Saudi Arabia over the past week, and Houthi leader Abdul Malik al-Houthi said all Saudi oil facilities could be targets.

The move has contributed in recent days to one of the war's sharpest rises in global oil prices, with Brent crude spiking above \$100 a barrel for the first time since May.

U.S. President Donald Trump on Friday vowed "major military punishment" for Tehran and the Houthis after the Houthi struck two Saudi tankers in the Red Sea.

An interim truce meant to end the war effectively collapsed two weeks ago, with U.S. forces striking targets in southern Iran in response to Iranian disruption of shipping in the Strait of Hormuz.

Trump has threatened in recent days to widen the range of targets to include Iran's energy plants and bridges, send ground forces to seize its oil hub of Kharg Island, and bomb a deep-underground nuclear-linked site known as Pickaxe Mountain.

On Friday, however, Trump said he had not yet made a decision on new major strikes.

"We are talking to them," he told reporters at the White House. "I think they're being serious. I think... they are being by far the most serious that we've seen them, but that doesn't mean we get there."



Maha TET paper leak case: Prime accused, aide held from Bihar

THANE: The alleged mastermind of Maharashtra Teacher Eligibility Test (TET) 2026 paper leak case was arrested from Bihar along with an associate, a senior Thane police official said on Saturday.

Alleged kingpin Vijayendrakumar Gupta alias Bijendra Kumar Gupta and his associate Indrajit Singh were nabbed from the eastern state on Friday by the special investigation team (SIT) probing the case, DCP, Bhiwandi Zone-II, Pawan Bansode said.

ED arrests ex-C'garh PSC chairman in paper 'leak' case

RAIPUR: The Enforcement Directorate on Saturday arrested former Chhattisgarh PSC chairman Tamas Singh Sonwani in Raipur on money laundering charges in an alleged examination paper leak case, officials said.

The probe pertains to the "leak" of question papers and "manipulation" of the state service examinations conducted in 2020 and 2021 by the Chhattisgarh Public Service Commission (CGPSC). ED will seek his custodial remand, an official said.

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THE WEEK THAT WAS
A quiz on the week's development.



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UP blaze building razed



The Lucknow Development Authority demolished the four-storey building in Aliganj where a fire killed 15 people last month after finding that large portions of the structure were illegally constructed and converted for commercial use. The authority issued a notice to the owners on June 23, asking them to establish the legality of the construction. DEEPAK GUPTA/HT

VOTER LIST ROW: COURT RESERVES ORDER ON PLEA AGAINST SONIA

NEW DELHI: A Delhi court on Saturday reserved its order on a revision connected with the issue of Congress leader Sonia Gandhi's name inclusion in the voter list. The revision petition has been filed by Vikas Tripathi, who has alleged that Sonia Gandhi's name was included in the voter list before she became a citizen of India.

Tripathi has sought the registration of an FIR in the matter after a magistrate court declined his plea. The order of the magistrate has now been challenged before the revisional court. Special Judge Vishal Gagne of the Rouse Avenue Court reserved the matter for pronouncement of orders on August 13. AGENCY

WB IPS OFFICER SUSPENDED OVER POLICE 'EXCESSES'

KOLKATA: West Bengal chief minister Suwendu Adhikari on Saturday announced the suspension of an Indian Police Service (IPS) officer, who was accused of showing a desecrated idol of Goddess Kali into a prison van in October 2023. He said that four other police officers in various police stations across the state, have also been suspended over similar allegations.

"An idol of Goddess Kali was desecrated during Kali Puja at Kakdwip in South 24 Parganas. Locals staged a protest as their religious sentiments were hurt. Koteswara Rao, the then Sundarban SP resorted to lathi charge to disperse the mob. He then shoved the idol in a prison van and took it to the police station. He has been suspended," he said. ITC

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A quiz on the week's development.



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A quiz on the week's development.

Sunday Hindustan Times

NEW DELHI SUNDAY JANUARY 22, 2023

HT TWTW THE WEEK THAT WAS

Take a cue from the clues

Authors who are not authors, leaders who no longer lead, a beauty queen walks her last walk, and cracks appear in a Himachal village. More happened this week. Take the quiz to find out

Natasha Rego

Ammaar Reshi (right) is the author of the children's book Alice and Sparkle (above). Who actually wrote and illustrated it?

1 Ammaar Reshi is not an author or illustrator, but he "wrote" Alice and Sparkle, a children's book which has sold over 900 copies since it was listed in Amazon in December. It features characters with typically crooked eyes and 12 fingers. Who actually wrote and illustrated it?

2 She's a lapsed Mormon and was briefly a DJ. Her partner Clarke Gayford is a fisherman. Her daughter Neve attended the UN General Assembly at three months. Last week she said, "You can be your own kind of leader—one who knows when it's time to..."

HT hindustantimes htItweets www.hindustantimes.com

FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.



REFLECTIONS

{ INCIDENTALLY }

Gopalkrishna Gandhi



When resignation cleanses and restores lost stature

The impulse to resign has to be seen as the dictate of conscience and needs to be acted upon in obedience to that inner goad

Dharmendra Pradhan should have resigned as Union education minister earlier. Perhaps—who knows—he wanted to and was prepared to but was not allowed to. I regret the fact that he did not leave earlier, not just because that would have saved the country the convulsions seen over the last three weeks but for another reason as well: Resignations, when they are real, are intensely personal decisions. They come from inner resolve. They are non-negotiable. Pradhan's resignation, partly for the reason of its delayed arrival, but more for what could seem like a lack of a clear inner conviction, would stop short of being such a relinquishment.

When resignations are demanded by the public through protests, and are then offered, they become less of a self-denial and more of a punishment inflicted. I cannot get myself to admire demands for an individual's resignation. Democratic demands for leaders of governments and of governments as a whole to resign, like Jayaprakash Narayan's in 1974, are another matter. Expectations for resignations that follow due process and come after responsibility, direct or vicarious, if a public wrong is established are also another matter. Two Union finance ministers led Prime Minister (PM) Jawaharlal Nehru's Cabinet in such circumstances—RK Shanmukham Chetty and TR Krishnamachari. When I refer

to "real" resignations by individuals, I am referring to resignations which are true and inwardly driven, in response to something which will not let them continue in office—when continuing is to lose one's self-respect. The individual concerned in a democracy must see and feel public opinion, and when he does, that realisation contributes to his personal decision. Two impulses are at work then: one's inner voice and the external voice, the voice of one's conscience and the voice of the people. Both heeded, in good time, make for resignations of the kind PM Nehru's Cabinet saw in the very dawn of Independence, resignations of such stature.

The very first Cabinet minister to send a letter of resignation to Nehru was—it may surprise the reader to know—none other than India's first deputy PM and home minister, Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel. Crushed in his innermost being by the assassination of his friend, Mahatma Gandhi, on January 30, 1948, he sent in his resignation. Without being aware of this, a correspondent wrote a letter to *The Statesman* dated February 3, 1948, which said, "Sardar Patel should resign for the failure of his security department to protect Mahatma Gandhi." Jayaprakash Narayan and other socialists asked for a new home minister. Was Patel stung? He was. Reminding Nehru of his earlier letter, he wrote another to him. "The *Statesman's* correspondent asked a constitutional stand. And I think he is right. This is an additional reason for my resignation. I do not wish to do anything to embarrass you at this critical juncture, but when there is a public demand, a challenge which is obviously justified, I feel I must once again request you to help me."

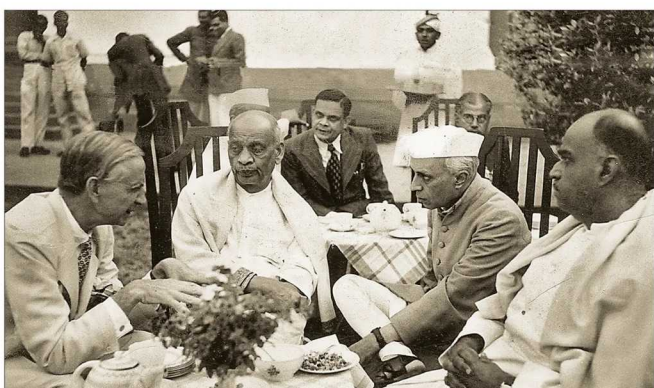
Patel asked his daughter Maniben to give it to his private secretary, Y Shankar for being

sent to its addressee. Rajmohan Gandhi tells us in his masterly biography of the great man (*Patel: A Life*, Navajivan, 1990) that Shankar said to Patel that the ministry could not be held responsible for destiny's role and "persuaded the Sardar to withhold it."

The same day as *The Statesman* carried the letter, he wrote to his senior colleague, "...in the crisis that we have to face now after Bapu's death, I think it is my duty, and I feel I must venture to say, yours also, for us to face it together as friends and colleagues..." The country was thereby enabled to have the indomitable leader's services for another two years before the death took place.

But 78 years on, the fact of Patel's reflexive act of statesmanship in seeking to leave office sends a powerful message: Resignations are meant to be given, not extorted. They are meant to be treated as something beyond office-holding or office-leaving. They are to be seen as a moral, not political, plea. And in a democracy, as a covenanted step. Consider Patel's line "...but when there is a public demand..."

Nehru—who was not going to, and did not, accept Patel's resignation—did not stop these other resignations (all conscience-driven) from materialising. The second minister VK Krishna Menon to go. The clamour became a crescendo. Menon had to go, and did. And as a teenager, I too celebrated his departure as a kind of cathartic relief and saw it as a victory of public opinion. It was only years later, reading Jairam Ramesh's biography of the man (*A Chequered Brilliance*, Penguin/Viking, 2019) that I came to know that Menon had, in fact, sent in his resignation much before the clamour for it grew. And that he cited public opinion



The fact of Sardar Patel's reflexive act of statesmanship in seeking to leave office sends a powerful message—resignations are meant to be given, not extorted. They are meant to be treated as something beyond office-holding or office-leaving.

helped the railway ministry with understated confidence, tendered his resignation. Nehru reluctantly accepted it. "It will be good," Shastri wrote in his letter of resignation. "...and the government as a whole, if I quietly quit the office I hold." The *Hindustan Times* special correspondent wrote, "More than the Government supporters, those in the opposition were flabbergasted..."

Eight years later, in 1962, after the Sino-Indian war, the country wanted defence minister VK Krishna Menon to go. The clamour became a crescendo. Menon had to go, and did. And as a teenager, I too celebrated his departure as a kind of cathartic relief and saw it as a victory of public opinion. It was only years later, reading Jairam Ramesh's biography of the man (*A Chequered Brilliance*, Penguin/Viking, 2019) that I came to know that Menon had, in fact, sent in his resignation much before the clamour for it grew. And that he cited public opinion

while doing so. The impulse to resign has to be seen as the dictate of conscience and needs to be acted upon in obedience to that inner goad. And the conscience of a minister in a democracy cannot but regard public opinion when justified as, to use Patel's telling phrase, "an additional challenge", a second goad. Resignations are self-cleansing. They go beyond political action to political reflection. To demand them can be natural, even necessary. But when given under that pressure, they become a succumbing.

Let those who clamoured for Pradhan to go, not celebrate his going for the manner of his going does not belong to the scroll of resignations as much as it does to the score of a chase. When they were chasing a policy and a programme, they were a great force chasing a wrong. When they started chasing a person, they began to resemble a pack chasing a prey. But let Pradhan also know that

had he acted earlier, his resignation would have given him a moral stature that would have replaced his political stature. In the end, no one can claim laurels. Except perhaps Sonam Wangchuk whose demands, towards the end of his fast, did not include a call for Pradhan's resignation.

Now the admittedly impressive movement started for education and examination reform must, after it has had a moment to recover from its protest-mode, show an altogether different aspect: An intense, chess-board-like focus on achieving goals that must transcend any single individual's departure from the scene. It is now time for the protest movement to retrieve the voice of the cause from the din of the chase.

Gopalkrishna Gandhi is a student of modern Indian history and the author of *The Unbinding Light: A Personal History of Independent India*. The views expressed are personal

{ SUNDAY SENTIMENTS }

Karan Thapar



Parting of speech: Birth of American English

George Bernard Shaw was spotted on when he declared that the US and England are two countries separated by a common language. But so too was Henry Higgins. In *My Fair Lady*, commenting on their accent, he said "In America they haven't spoken it for years."

A recent essay by David Robson on the BBC website to mark the sesquicentennial anniversary of American independence explains how American English was born. It's a fascinating story.

Did the founding fathers of the US insist on a new way of speaking? It seems Thomas Jefferson did. In August 1812 he wrote: "So great growing a population, spread over such an extent of country, with such a variety of climates, of productions, of arts, must enlarge their language, to make it answer its purpose of embracing all ideas, the new as well as the old. The new circumstances under which we are placed, call for new words, new phrases, and for the transfer of old words

to new objects." By this time, however, the British were complaining about American contamination of the purity of English. As early as 1756 Samuel Johnson defined the American "dialect" as "a tract (trace) of corruption".

Thus, Americans began to call football "soccer" and autumn "fall". But both of those, incidentally, were older English words that had fallen into disuse in the mother country. That's also true of gotten, which Americans prefer to the British got.

Many of the other words which the Americans coined came from Algonquian languages such as skunk, raccoon, chipmunk, moose, opossum and caribou. In many instances, the Americans gave a distinctly Yankee flavour to their choice of terminology.

Bills instead of bank notes, mad for angry, smart for clever, pet to mean stroke, and sick to describe a general state of illness rather than a stomach upset. Ask a New Yorker for a jug of

water and he's bound to respond, "Do you mean a pitcher?"

Noah Webster in the 18th century took the process of Americanisation of English one step further by changing the spelling. His justification was simple: "As an independent nation, our honour requires us to have a system of our own, in language as well as government." Of course, he spelt honour as honor. In fact, he's responsible for omitting the 'u' in favour of 'o', and for the single 'l' in words like "travelled" as well as the conversion of "draught" to "draft". To him is also attributed the American spelling of centre, i.e., "center".

It took the American people a while to accustom themselves to Webster's spellings. But they did. Today, the spellcheck on American computers imposes their preferred spelling over your correct English one. I spend a lot of my time amending what the computer has irritatingly but unstopably done. Today when an American travels his luggage is his baggage and what adorns his legs is pants not trousers. This is liable to be misunderstood by the British. For them baggage has a very different meaning and pants are usually worn inside your trousers.

Robson points out that the American term "dude"—which we often use in India—refers to an American-born male who has failed to embrace his American identity and, instead, aspires to British fashion and language. So, be careful the next time you call someone a dude. It's not what you think it is. It's not smart to

AS US MARKS ITS 250TH INDEPENDENCE ANNIVERSARY, YOU COULD ASK IF JEFFERSON WAS RIGHT WHEN HE HOPED THAT AS AMERICAN ENGLISH GAINED STRENGTH 'TIS NEW CHARACTER MAY SEPARATE IT IN NAME AS WELL AS IN POWER FROM THE MOTHER-TONGUE'

be one. It's a distinctly pejorative term. So, as the US marks its 250th independence anniversary, you could ask if Jefferson was right when he hoped that as American English gained strength "its new character may separate it in name as well as in power from the mother-tongue". The answer isn't straight forward. American English is different. There's no doubt about that. Both in words and their pronunciation. But the British can easily understand what the Yanks are saying. To that extent, Jefferson did not succeed. That suggests it's more a dialect than a different language. Would you disagree?

Karan Thapar is the author of *Devil's Advocate: The Untold Story*. The views expressed are personal

{ ENGENDER }

Lalita Panicker



Women are writing new rules for conservation

Conservation is not just ecological but also social, and there can be no capacity-building in this field without gender empowerment. Across India, women are playing a leading role in conservation. Mehreen Khaleel studies endangered species such as the Himalayan gray langur and trains young Kashmiri women in conservation. Khaleel's work emphasises environmental education and human-wildlife conflict resolution, particularly addressing challenges faced by wildlife due to habitat changes.

This dual focus on ecology and capacity-building is ground-breaking in Kashmir, where conservation has often been male-dominated. Her approach ensures the creation of a new generation of women leaders in environmental stewardship. The valuable work of women in conservation remains most localised. Many could become templates for other regions of India.

In Lahaul, Himachal Pradesh, Sapna Khando helps farmers protect their crops from Himalayan brown bears by installing camera traps and deterrent lights around agricultural fields. This blends scientific monitoring with community participation.

Rimmo Tasso's More Conservation Foundation in Arunachal Pradesh focuses on conserving species like the red panda and mishi takin while restoring habitats and supporting nature-based livelihoods. The innovation here is the emphasis on local stewardship. Conservation is nurtured within communities, ensuring long-term sustainability rooted in cultural and ecological ties.

The Super Meimee collective in Arunachal Pradesh has created a nature education programme rooted in local culture, expanding into responsible tourism (Super Meimee Adventures). These women have transformed their traditional knowledge into structured nature education and immersive tourism experiences. Super Meimee Adventures generates income while sustaining conservation education, creating a circular model.

where livelihoods, culture, and ecology reinforce one another. It is helping children see their village not as a place to leave behind, but as a place whose understanding and caring for. Many of the lessons come from their own lived experiences. The women are also rediscovering the value of their own knowledge. Monisha Babel, co-founder, North-East Network, says, "Brushing aside past traumas of conflict and anger in this region, women continued to toil as farmers, seed stores and producers. What we need now is for their community to recognise their collective strength and shared resilience in order to bring about an equitable future toward their well-being and security."

In Chhattisgarh, Bhumiika Yadav has pioneered a nature education initiative that bridges indigenous ecological knowledge and structured learning. Her project, *Harar Jungle La Ham Padho*, engages Baiga children in activities like birdwatching, storytelling, and art, while also developing biodiversity learning materials in collaboration with the forest department. This replicable education model strengthens conservation awareness while addressing gaps in rural schooling.

Lahmunsiani Pachau has turned waste management into a conservation innovation in Mizoram. Her community tackles single-use plastics through a waste-handling system that generates livelihoods. Her initiative includes school-based conservation education and collaboration with government departments, making waste management a community-owned solution. Sonali Ghosh, chief conservator and head of department, Bodoland Territorial Council and director, Mams National Park, says local youth are channelling their love for nature into skills for protecting it. Women have become conservation role models in their communities and are willing to share knowledge with the next generation.

The views expressed are personal

NEET can't continue as a make-or-break exam

Ten decades ago, on a hot Sunday afternoon, I was writing what felt like the most important exam of my life. It was a day I had been preparing for over two years. My parents, probably, had been preparing for it since the day they first thought of having a child. It was the IIT-JEE. Back then, there were no JEE Mains and JEE Advanced. The first stage was called the JEE Screening, and cleared about 15,000 students, clearly to earn the right to write the final examination. The second stage was the JEE Mains. I managed to clear the first level, and was seated at a desk, waiting for the invigilator to distribute the mathematics question paper. Our guy was particularly a bit annoyed, forced to work on a Sunday, a day he would have spent with his family. But here he was, "invigilating" 40 odd kids who would never forget those two hours for the rest of their lives.

My examination centre was familiar territory—the same school where I had sat for the Class XII board exams. There was something reassuring about walking through those gates again. A famous alumnus of that school, Mahendra Singh Dhoni, wasn't passed out yet.

The question papers, of 60 marks, were soon passed around—12 questions, five marks each. The first question was an arithmetic progression problem. I took my own sweet time to solve it; then, I moved on to an "area under the curve" question.



Abhishek Asthana

As I finished plotting the graph, I looked around, to see if a familiar shape appeared in someone else's answer sheet. I am not proud of this, but it is an involuntary response for most.

And then, I saw the kid next to me with his eyes closed, leg bandaged, with a blot of fresh blood in the centre. I could see a few drops of blood on the floor too. He was in immense pain, but he persisted with finding that definite integral.

Maybe he faced an accident on the way to the centre, not only had he three seconds of mindspace to give to this tragedy—10 other questions were staring at me. I had lived 1,000-plus kilometres away from my parents for two years for these two hours, same as probably most of the 40 kids in that room, all bearing injuries, mental if not physical. Imagine being the eldest child of the family, with two siblings. You do well at the school in your small town, always in the top three, have never lost a mark in mathematics, and the teachers are vocally proud of you. Your father thinks you are his best bet. And he moves mountains to get you the best coaching, the best teachers, and the best IIT factory on his clerical salary. Offer a sunk cost. But, loans are taken, modest lodgings mortgaged, siblings deprived, and numerous other pains taken by numerous people you call your own. All of this will play in your head when you aren't able to solve a problem, sweating, or even bleeding, in 40 degrees



When you aren't able to solve a problem, sweating, or even bleeding, in 40 degrees heat, all you see is your parents' face, and that mortgaged house.

Now imagine there are no other exams you can take, this is the only one in the year you have to pass to get into your preferred college. Or any college an education loan can afford. That exam is called NEET.

There are no second chances, if you can't make it to the—64,000 government-college seats that two million students are fighting for; a private college seat is 10x or even more expensive.

And that's why there are NEET suicides—32 in 2025. Add to this the uncertainty of a paper leak, and an already vulnerable mind may see no other path. That's why we need to reform this examination system. The first thing is to fortify this day, when the nation stops for that two million kids can reach their centres in time. Question-setters need to be isolated till the exam is

completed. It's a job for the army, not the academicians. Look at how China conducts the *Gaokao*.

NEET should be offered twice a year, so a kid who had a bad day can still believe that all is not lost. When you have converged all entrance exams into one, you can't have a single point of failure. The concept isn't a pipit. CBSE Class X board will be held twice a year, and anyone can write it the second time, even to improve scores. Twenty years ago, I secured a rank of 5,433. It wasn't enough to get into an IIT, but I did all right in my life later because I got more chances. Let's give our children more attempts and keep it fair. They will surely make us proud.

Abhishek Asthana is a tech and media entrepreneur, and tweets as @gobbbarsingh. The views expressed are personal

{ SUNDAY LETTERS }

Need for diplomacy in West Asia

This is with reference to "The answers we don't have on US-Iran war" by Karan Thapar (July 19). Escalating threats and military actions only increase the risk of a wider regional war. Diplomacy remains the only sustainable path to peace. The world must encourage negotiations to prevent escalation.

Sanjay Chopra

Major gains in women's higher ed enrollment

This is with reference to "Women are choosing classrooms over chores" by Namita Bhandare (July 19). The changing mindsets of parents, and the growing aspirations of women have led to them focussing more on higher education. Government programs encouraging women's education have helped shift perspectives, especially in rural India.

Abhilasha Das

While Rupa's progress is encouraging, the UP Governor's statement is disheartening. To ensure these women graduates end up having a good job, it is essential that universities and colleges work in tandem with India Inc.

Bal Govind

Write to us at: letters@hindustantimes.com

Arbitration starting to look like process it was to replace: CJI

Abraham Thomas
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NEW DELHI: Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant on Saturday said that present-day arbitration is starting to look like the very court process it was meant to replace, flagging delays in awards and proceedings extending into multi-day hearings and heavy documentation.

"We now see multi-day hearings. We see heavy document production modelled on common law discovery. We see competing experts on every point. And we see awards that take years, not months. Arbitration is starting to look like the very court process it was meant to replace," he said.

He produced the latest data by the International Chamber of Commerce (ICC) to illustrate the long delays in arbitral disputes that take an average of 26 months to reach a final award. The London Court of International Arbitration's (LCIA) figures show a median of 20 months. "By the standards of our conventional courts, these numbers are not shocking. But they are a long way from the speed arbitration once promised".

While admitting that the foundations of International Arbitration remain sound, he said that over time, layers of procedure have obscured the efficiency and flexibility for which he suggested tribunals manage proceedings with discipline, set realistic schedules at the outset, and ensure they are followed.

Speaking on the topic, "International Arbitration: Navigating New Realities and Stress-testing the Fundamentals" at the Annual India Conference of the Singapore International Arbitration Centre (SIAC) in Delhi, CJI Kant highlighted four areas of concern. These include, besides a strong case management, balanced transparency, sensible use of technology, and, restraint from the courts when asked to enforce arbitral awards.

He said courts must resist the urge to second-guess arbitrators as it poses a real risk of inconsistency, the very thing that undermines predictability between parties in arbitration proceedings. "As arbitration begins to confront disputes involving digital assets and other AI-driven technologies, that distinctly human role will become even more important".

Have fun with facts on Sundays

Catch the latest column of



A quiz on the week's development.

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Sunday Hindustan Times

NEW DELHI
SUNDAY
JANUARY 22, 2023

TWTW
THE WEEK THAT WAS

Take a cue from the clues

Authors who are not authors, leaders who no longer lead, a beauty queen walks her last walk, and cracks appear in a Himachal village. More happened this week. Take the quiz to find out

Ammar Reshi (right) is the author of the children's book Alice and Sparkle (above). Who actually wrote and illustrated it?

1 Ammar Reshi is not an author or illustrator, but he "wrote" Alice and Sparkle, a children's book which has sold over 900 copies since it was listed in Amazon in December. It features characters with typically crooked eyes and 12 fingers. Who actually wrote and illustrated it?

2 She's a lapsed Mormon and was briefly a DJ. Her partner Clarke Gayford is a fisherman. Her daughter Neve attended the UN General Assembly at three months. Last week she said, "You can be your own kind of leader—one who knows when it's time to

Natasha Rego

Ammar Reshi

Neve

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WORLD

H10

Brazil blocks visas of US envoys over poll interference

BRASILIA: Brazil has denied visa requests for two US officials who planned to cast doubt on the integrity of its electoral system in an attempt to shape Brazil's October presidential election, two Brazilian officials said. **REUTERS**

Trump vows tariffs on Canada over wildfires

WASHINGTON: Donald Trump on Friday vowed tariffs on Canada in retaliation for smoke from wildfires that has drifted into US. **REUTERS**

Teenager slain by US singer D4vd had abortion

LOS ANGELES: The 13-year-old girl, Celeste Rivas Hernandez, killed and dismembered by US singer D4vd had an abortion after their sexual encounter, a US court was told. **AFP**

35 killed in Syria after 2 passenger buses collide

DAMASCUS: Thirty-five people were killed when two passenger buses crashed in a desert region of Syria, while 30 others were injured. **AFP**

Paramount delays closing Warner buyout for 1 year

NEW YORK: Paramount and Warner Bros Discovery have agreed to delay closing their \$81 billion merger to next year as a judge considers a challenge from 12 states seeking to block the deal. **AP**

Court rejects Trump bid to revive H-1B fee

Press Trust of India

letters@hindustantimes.com

WASHINGTON: A US federal appeals court has refused to stay down the Trump administration's decision to impose a US\$100,000 fee on H-1B visas for highly skilled foreign workers.

The three-judge bench at the Boston-based First Circuit Court of Appeals denied the federal government's motion to stay US District Judge Leo T. Sorokin's June 8 ruling that struck down the fee, terming it an unlawful tax not authorised by Congress.

"...we deny the defendants' motion to stay pending appeal to this court, the district court's June 8, 2026, Memorandum and Order and accompanying Judgment," the bench ruled on Friday.

The judges agreed with the

plaintiffs — 20 Democrat-run states — that "the question here is not whether Congress may delegate the authority in question. It is whether Congress has done so."

Donald Trump had issued a proclamation in September last year imposing a \$100,000 fee for obtaining new H-1B visas.

The H-1B visa is a non-immigrant visa that allows US companies to employ foreign workers in specialty occupations that require theoretical or technical expertise. American technology companies depend on it to hire tens of thousands of employees each year from countries like India and China.

Citing a 1989 US Supreme Court ruling, the appeals court said the executive must show that Congress had spoken "clearly" in conferring discretionary authority to impose

financial burdens, whether described as "fees" or "taxes".

"However, the Trump administration has not explained why that clear standard isn't required in this case," the order said.

The court also said the administration had failed to show why the plaintiff states would not suffer substantial injury if the stay was denied.

The US issues 65,000 H-1B visas annually, along with an additional 20,000 visas for foreign workers holding advanced educational qualifications. These visas usually cost between USD 2,000 and USD 5,000 in fees.

Not where it belongs



The tail of an airplane protrudes from the roof of a house after a crash in Ganderkesee, Lower Saxony in Germany on Saturday. The plane carrying two people lost altitude for reasons still unknown and crashed into the single-family home. One person died and the second is missing. **AFP**

Mojtaba more likely to pursue nukes: US intel

Asian News International

letters@hindustantimes.com

WASHINGTON/TEHRAN: United States intelligence agencies assess that Iran's new Supreme Leader, Mojtaba Khamenei, is more open to building nuclear arms than his predecessor and father, according to a report by The New York Times.

The intelligence evaluation, compiled prior to the ongoing war from sources including wiretapped communications, indicates that Mojtaba displays fewer reservations regarding nuclear weaponisation than Ali Khamenei, who was regarded as more reserved on the issue.

US officials said the assessment stems from an interpretation of earlier material rather than new intelligence gathered after Mojtaba took power.

Washington now assesses that internal Iranian factions advocating for a nuclear deterrent have gained significant traction, arguing that nuclear capability is required to prevent future military aggression.

In a related development, The Wall Street Journal reported that Israeli intelligence believes Iran has relocated thousands of centrifuges into a deeply forti-



A screen grab shows clouds of smoke rising after strikes on the Saudi Aramco refinery in Jazan on Saturday. **AFP**

fied underground complex near Natanz, referred to as Pickaxe Mountain. The subsurface construction of the facility renders it largely resilient to aerial bombardment.

Iran's first 'peaceful night' following 13 days of strikes

In a brief respite following nearly two weeks of intense military action, Iran reported an absence of overnight bombard-

ment on Saturday, signalling an interruption to 13 consecutive nights of American military strikes. Iranian Health Ministry spokesperson Hossein Kermanpour confirmed the pause via a post on X, stating, "Iran had a peaceful night."

United States Central Command did not immediately state the operational pause, breaking its previous daily routine of announcing fresh offensive actions over the last 13 days.

NEPAL TO KEEP CONTROVERSIAL MAP ON NEW ONE-RUPEE COIN

Press Trust of India

letters@hindustantimes.com

KATHMANDU: Nepal will mint the newly designed one-rupee coin that depicts the controversial map, including the territories of Limpiyadhura, Lipulek and Kalapani, the country's national bank said on Saturday.

Nepal claims the territories as their own, whereas India maintains that these are part of Uttarakhand and has said the issue should be addressed through bilateral dialogue.

Nepal's then K P Sharma Oli-led government in May 2020 included the territories in its official map.

Nepal Rastra Bank (NRB) spokesperson Guru Prasad Paudel said that the bank will issue the new one-rupee coin depicting the country's map showing these territories as part of it.

On July 20, the government had approved replacing the Nepal map on the one-rupee coin with a monastery.

However, the government, reportedly coming under pressure from the opposition and the general public, has decided to retain the map on its one-rupee coin.

{ WHITE HOUSE CORRESPONDENTS' DINNER }

Trump bashes 'fake news,' stokes 2028 return furore

Agence France-Presse

letters@hindustantimes.com

WASHINGTON: US President Donald Trump lashed out at "fake news media" and talked about serving a banned third term as he addressed a rescheduled White House correspondents dinner Friday, three months after the event was disrupted by an assassination attempt.

"This place is really the largest group of Trump derangement syndrome people ever put

together at one time," Trump said at the Waldorf Astoria hotel in Washington. He started with a relatively conciliatory tone, reflecting on the attack by a gunman that forced him to be evacuated from the dinner in April. "The show must go on," Trump said. But he quickly pivoted to attacking a wide range of perceived enemies in an often rambling speech, starting with journalists before training his fire on Democratic opponents.

Trump also revived talk about

serving a third term, which is barred under the US constitution, even as he insisted he was joking. "Just like my presidency, the second time is always better. And the third time is better yet," Trump said, before adding: "I'm only kidding." He later doubled down, pulling out a red "Trump 2028" cap and saying he was "pleased to announce my intention to -- and this is a somewhat of a scoop -- my intention to run for a fourth term as president of the United States."



Trump throws a 'Trump 2028' cap at the event. **REUTERS**

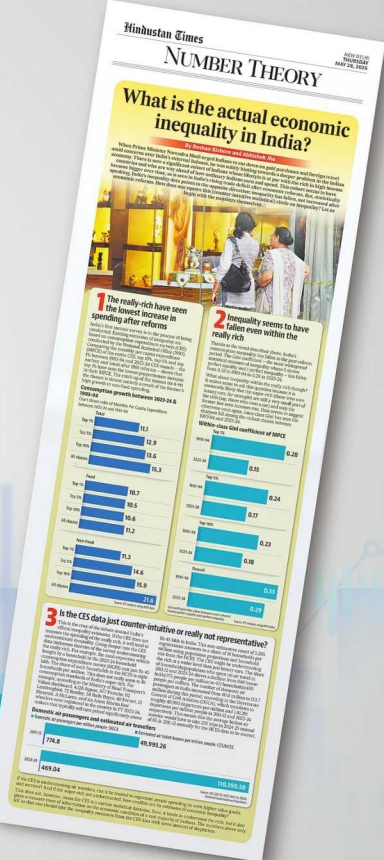
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HT wkend

A PART OF YOUR EVERYDAY LIFE

Patrice Lawrence

Writing wrong

Growing up in working-class White neighbourhoods, spending years in foster care, Lawrence sought refuge in books. But even there, there was no one like her – except on the wrong side of things. The tales she read contained racial slurs and ridicule, she recalls. Years later, as a writer, she decided to aim her stories at troubled children who felt invisible, as she had. They have resonated much further than she expected. Lawrence is now UK's children's laureate, tasked with promoting books and reading. 'It's like a Doctor Who regeneration,' she says

Kanika Sharma

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Patrice Lawrence knows what it's like to feel as if the world has no place in it for you. As a child, she spent four years in foster care, raised by a White working-class family until her mother could reclaim her.

There were few people of colour in her school. Even the books she loved and escaped into offered little resonance. These were all stories about White people, with Black people mocked, derided and at the fringes, when they appeared at all.

"I always felt different... acknowledging that still hurts," she says.

It was only decades later, as a 32-year-old NGO worker, that the full force of this alienation hit her.

Lawrence, a Trinidadian-origin Briton, was watching a BBC series called *Pig-Heart Boy* (1999; based on a novel of the same name), about a Black teen conflicted over having a pig's heart transplanted into his chest, when she realised: Here was a good, loving British family, and they just happened to all be Black.

At this point, Lawrence had spent years working in the area of child rights. Now, she realised she had more than one way to reach out. She began to write.

Her first book, *Orangeboy*, was about a 16-year-old on a date who finds himself caught in a gang war. It won a Waterstones prize in 2017.

Among her 15 other titles are *Our Story Starts in Africa* (2022; a picture book about Black history and heritage), *Is That Your Mama?* (2023; about mixed-race families), and *Needle* (2022; a young-adult novel about a teen caught in the criminal justice system).

With each story, Lawrence says, she aims to send a message to troubled young people: I see you, and you matter.

Her tales have now earned her the title of UK's Children's Laureate. She is the second Black woman to hold it.

"It's like a Doctor Who Time Lord regeneration: a new face, a new mission, built upon everything that has gone before," says Lawrence, 59.

"This gives me a much larger platform on which to talk about the impact of children's books and stories."

Excerpts from an interview.

In what you describe as "an increasingly divided" Britain, in an increasingly divided world, how do you write in ways that are realistic but help give hope to children?

Well, I believe the majority of humans do care about each other. I see it in everyday kindnesses, and it is very much in evidence among children and young people in schools.

I imbued a sense of hope in my stories, but also ensure that there are consequences for damaging behaviour. Marlon, the protagonist of *Orangeboy*, is a prime example. When he grabs a bag of drugs from his girlfriend, one bad decision sends things spinning out of control.

This is primarily a story about why good people make bad decisions, and how social capital provides a safety net if we do make bad decisions. There are three young men in *Orangeboy*, all dealing with the legacy of a brother's behaviour. Who pulls through and who doesn't? And why?

It is about how violence has consequences – but so does abandoning vulnerable young people without support.

When writing about grief, racism and violence in stories for children, are there lines you won't cross or themes you won't touch?

As a child, I always read a wide variety of books. The damaging books were the ones that contained racial slurs, and told me that Black people had no value in the world.

The original version of Hugh Lofting's *The Story of Doctor Dolittle* (1920) contains numerous offensive caricatures of African people. I read that one and its sequels when I was six or seven years old.

I don't believe in book censorship, but I do believe in critical thinking.

Books can be the starting point for com-

plex and difficult conversations. I think children understand this.

There have been many emotional moments during visits to schools when young people have told me why my stories are relatable to them. I'm grateful for every one of those moments. Each one is a reminder of why it's important that young people who feel undervalued in our world see their experiences acknowledged in writing.



Do you believe there's a way to turn a child's attention from screen to page?

There have always been distractions to reading, long before tech! Books have always endured, as a way to build community, spend time with friends, escape.

At local events, I see children from all backgrounds cheering themselves hoarse when they meet their favourite writers.

I meet fans in school libraries, creating murder mystery sessions or luring other young people in with games of *Dungeons & Dragons*. I meet them at conferences, giving up their weekends to meet each other and learn from each other.

As children's laureate, one mission is to build an evidence base to prove that shared reading provides tangible benefits to vulnerable children. Then use this data at a policy level to persuade decision-makers to give long-term support to libraries and reading initiatives.

A book is a reassuring companion when the real world feels too overwhelming.

Titles released in 2016, 2017 and 2022.

What would be your message to a child who feels stories are everywhere – in game worlds, Instagram and the movies – and needn't necessarily be sought out in books?

Stories are powerful. That's why tech becomes addictive. That's why advertisements lure us into buying things that we don't really need... by telling compelling stories about how much better our lives will be if we buy a certain product.

Books, including comic books, give you back control. You can pick and choose. You can decide when to pause, reflect, read on – or throw the book across the room in disgust. And, if you have a public library, books are free!

1 A children's laureate is selected based on nominations by librarians, critics, writers, booksellers and advocacy groups, vetted by a panel appointed by the children's reading charity BookTrust.

2 As UK's children's laureate for the next two years, Patrice Lawrence, 59, can now launch campaigns to promote books and reading. She is the second Black woman to hold the title.

3 "Growing up, I read books that told me Black people had no value in the world," she says. "I don't believe in critical thinking. Books can be the starting point for that."

inside

LIFESTYLE

Shots heard around the world

It's been 200 years since the first photograph was taken (left). It was a blurry view but felt like magic: an image crafted by light. More spells have been cast since. Pictures have changed how we travel and eat, what we see in the mirror (and how often we look). They have helped pass better laws; changed our views on war. Take a look



CULTURE

Settling the score

Messi's last pirouette, the genius of Spain, what ails the Video Assistant Referee: Read Kunal Pradhan's football World Cup wrap

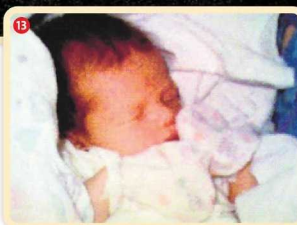
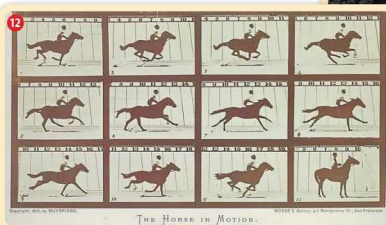
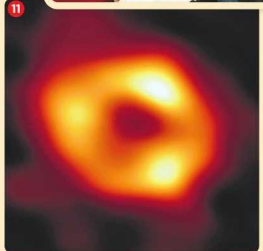
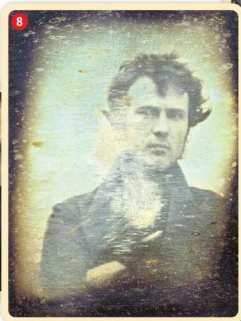
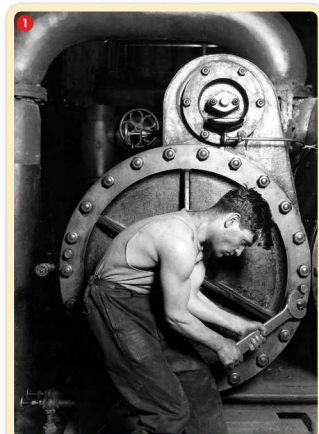
URBAN

Grand quest auto

Potholes, traffic, hawkers, honking... India's roads are not for beginners. In a wry twist, developers are working this chaos into videogames. Race against rickshaws, chase litterers for clues, dodge wedding bands, and wander through civic offices where nothing can be found. In-game, you get to bend the rules too



wknd lifestyle



Shots heard around the world

It's been 200 years since the first photograph: a blurry view, captured over hours. It still felt like magic — an image crafted by light. More spells have been cast since then. Photographs have changed how we travel, what we eat, what we see in the mirror (and how often we look). They have helped pass better laws; changed our views on war. K Narayanan & Anesha George have more

BY THE
NUMBERS:

1. Power House Mechanic by Lewis Hine; 1920.
2. The macaque Punch who went viral with his stuffed toy: 2026.
3. The first recognisable image: View from Window at Le Gras, by Nicéphore Niepce; 1826.
4. Earthrise by astronaut Bill Anders, the first colour photo of Earth; 1968.
5. Beyoncé's pregnancy post on Instagram in 2017.
6. Cannonballs on a battlefield in the Crimean war: Roger Fenton, 1855.
7. The Oscars selfie; 2014.

K Narayanan

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"Travel becomes a strategy for accumulating photographs," the American essayist Susan Sontag wrote, in 1977. "A picture is also a way of refusing it — by limiting experience to a search for the photographic, by converting experience into an image, a souvenir."

The camera has, for centuries, been something of a disruptor. But it started out quite differently: as the science of understanding how certain chemicals and materials responded to light.

When Nicéphore Niepce took the first photograph, in 1826, it was a process that required hours of exposure. It was a scientific miracle: a picture drawn by light itself. (Those hours of exposure meant that early images couldn't capture people. Anything that moved was essentially blurred out.)

Niepce left his notes to Frenchman Louis Daguerre, who created the commercially viable photographic process.

By the mid-19th century, photography was common enough, and exclusive enough, that Abraham Lincoln and Queen Victoria had their pictures taken. In an odd twist of fate, the first wanted poster to feature a picture was the one for Lincoln's assassin, John Wilkes Booth, in 1865.

The first paparazzi image would follow not long after, in 1898, when two men snuck

into a picture of German leader Otto von Bismarck, aged 83 and on his deathbed.

Then, in 1900, the Kodak Brownie, a cardboard box camera created to promote sales of Kodak film rolls, went on sale for \$1 (about the price of a good dress shirt). Designed to make photography accessible to the masses, it promoted the idea of a "snapshot" — a picture taken for fun or personal memory, rather than grand event or ceremony — and sparked generations of amateur photographers.

By the time Sontag wrote her 1977 essay, On Photography, the technology had been democratized.

There were photojournalists documenting the war in Vietnam. Photographs marked the Kennedy assassination. Nature photography, pioneered by the intrepid British brothers Richard Kearton and Cherry Kearton in 1892 (they disguised themselves as trees and animals to get candid images of wildlife), truly came into its own, with National Geographic's famous Tibet issue of 1905 marking its transition to a photo-based magazine.

Fashion photography bloomed, and the rise of studio publicity and portraits made

ABOUT 61,000 PHOTOS ARE TAKEN EVERY SECOND, WORLDWIDE. ABOUT 14 BILLION ARE SHARED DAILY. WE NO LONGER EVEN NOTICE CAMERAS AROUND US

superstars of Hollywood photographers such as Richard Avedon and Cecil Beaton.

There were significant barriers still. Cameras were expensive. Film roll was expensive too. And photo printing involved treatment with silver halide, also expensive.

A small shake of the hand or movement of the subject could ruin the picture, and it was rare that every shot on a roll would turn out well. Being a photographer required resources, commitment and patience.

In India, it was a hobby only the rich could afford. But preserving the moment was a universal desire. So, photo studios mushroomed. People visited them dressed in wedding finery or graduation gowns, to stand against elaborate backdrops of elephants or beaches, or to sit on tinfoil thrones.

There were also photo days, when a camera and roll of film, and the family would get all dressed up and pose. A few weeks later, he would return with an envelope full of images that they joyfully examined, then preserved in black-leaved photo albums.

There were photo days at school, which remained the only record of friends and classmates, for generations of students through the 20th century, all the way until digital cameras became common.

These erased the need for film, and suddenly, occasion didn't matter. There was no cost of production.

Then the camera shrunk into the phone, marking the culmination of Sontag's statement about photography "limiting experience to a search for the photographic".

It wasn't just travel now; dining, cooking, unwinding and even sex became reasons to take a photograph, with the importance of the image often superseding the act itself.

The ubiquity of the photograph has led to the acceptance of the surveillance state. We barely notice the cameras around us, and pay little attention to the monitoring devices that permeate our everyday.

Meanwhile, we don't retain full ownership of our images. We store them on servers

owned by tech companies. The abundance of images is used in a myriad of ways, including as training grounds for facial recognition programs and artificial intelligence.

About 5 billion photos are taken every day, worldwide; or about 61,000 a second. About 14 billion are shared every day; with WhatsApp accounting for nearly half this traffic.

The selfie camera and Instagram have turned the photograph, once an art form designed to encourage new views of the world, into the ultimate tool of self-obsession; and the ultimate time sink.

There are probably more great pictures taken today than at any time in the history of the camera. Yet, perhaps because the iconic photos of today sweep through a short-attention-span internet or become memes for a period of time, we would find ourselves hard-pressed to name our era's counterparts to the Great Depression's Dorothea Lange and Walker Evans.

Abundance has created anonymity. There are still photographers, professional and amateur, who record events: births, deaths, marriages, engagements, baby showers, school plays, birthday parties. But there are no physical albums, no communal poring over stacks of printed photographs. Instead, there are Instagram posts and WhatsApp links, pictures seen in asynchronous isolation on mobile devices, with approval expressed in terse emojis.

Servers fill up with lost memories. Giga-bytes sit on abandoned platforms.

Photography still certifies experience. But there are so many experiences staged for photographs that the value of both is lost.

(K Narayanan writes on films, videogames, books and, occasionally, technology)



CHECK OUT a slide show of more seminal images from the past 200 years



[FAME BY FRAME] TALES TOLD IN PIXELS

Critical exposure: The turning points

8. Robert Cornelius in world's first selfie: 1839.

9. Footballer Colin Kaepernick takes a knee: 2016.

10. The award-winning AI image by Boris Eldagsen: 2023.

11. The first-ever image of a black hole: 2019.

12. Horse in Motion by Eadweard Muybridge: 1878.

13. Philippe Kohn rigs a digicam to his phone to take a photo of his baby: 1997.

14. Plastic waste near the corpses of migratory birds in Antarctica: 2026.

Anesha George

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There's an uncanny resemblance between the hands drawn in a cave in Indonesia 10,000 years ago (see image at right) and the gesture we use to get our phones to take photos today. We have, for millennia, been attempting to record the moment.

From art on stone, to glass plates, film and pixels, the journey to a world of #PicsOrItDiddntHappen has been revolutionary. Here's how the earliest photos worked.

Still life

By the early 1820s, French landowner Nicéphore Niepce had invented the art of heliography. It used light to harden and darken the surface of metal plates coated with asphalt and placed inside a box with a small hole and lens. As the light hit the plate, the surface darkened to form an image. The "unexposed" parts were washed away with oil to reveal a scene crafted by light. These images were captured over several hours, but tended to be blurry.

As he refined his methods, in 1826, Niepce took the world's first recognisable picture: of rooftops and the countryside surrounding his estate. (See Image 3 above)

Then Niepce died, in 1833, leaving his notes to the Parisian painter Louis Daguerre. For six years, Daguerre refined his friend's process until he had invented the daguerrotype, which used mercury vapour to render detailed images — in just 30 minutes.

His Boulevard du Temple (1838; scan the

culture

Settling the score

Messi's last pirouette, the genius of Spain, what ails VAR: Kunal Pradhan's World Cup wrap



Messi proved he could still go toe to toe with players born after he made his World Cup debut, 20 years ago. *AFP*

Kunal Pradhan

Every football World Cup tells a story. Beyond the winners and almost-winners, the happy surprises and bitter heartbreaks, it tells us a little more about the world we inhabit. If the 2018 World Cup was about France's superstars ruling from on high, and 2022 about Lionel Messi fighting to claim his crown at long last, what did the 2026 World Cup teach us about life and football? Here are three takeaways.

Wolf in GOAT's clothing
Last Sunday, Messi stepped into position for the final pirouette of his last dance. A dance that seemed both unlikely and unnecessary for a 39-year-old. A dance we thought he had already danced in 2022, when the greatest club player of all time ensconced himself as the greatest with no caveats.

From his opening strike in the 17th minute of the group match against Algeria, Messi scored above everyone else on the pitch. He would be ambling idly for large portions of the game, conserving energy, but constantly getting himself into positions from where he could unleash turbocharged mayhem when one least expected.

There were long stretches when he and his team seemed ineffective. But a crossover here, a nutmeg there, and the ball would be in the back of the net. Messi's dance was a tango where lingering cat-like arches morphed into lightning-fast flicks and turns. He may not have finished it the way he wanted to in the final against Spain (we'll get to that in a bit), but he proved one last time that he could go toe to toe with players born after he'd made his World Cup debut 20 years ago, hogging the headlines amid wars and protests.

The system (almost) always wins
The Spanish football team, which proved to be Messi's nemesis in the end, arrived at

the World Cup as reigning Euro champions. They had a reputation for being able to move the ball around as deftly as the legendary 2010 Spain team that won the World Cup—with one critical difference: hardly any member of the current squad would have made it into the galaxy of stars from 16 years ago.

The midfield of Rodri, Fabian Ruiz and Dani Olmo was not in the same league as Xavi, Iniesta, Busquets and Koke Alonso. The forwards Lamine Yamal, Alex Baena and Mikel Oyarzabal were a step behind the David Villa and Fernando Torres partnership. Defenders Pedro Porro, Pau Cubarsi, Aymeric Laporte and Marc Cucurella could not compare with Sergio Ramos, Carlos Puyol, Gerard Pique and Joan Capdevila.

So pundits did not favour Spain as heavily as they did France, Argentina, England and Brazil, at the start of the tournament.

What they overlooked was that the Spanish football system is so robust, and so central to how the team plays, that the personnel don't matter as much. This first became apparent in the 10 last-16 win against Portugal, when Spain kept knocking at the door before finding a winner in the 90th minute. Then in the semi-final against France, where the odds-on favourites were run off the pitch.

In the final, the Spanish system did not give Argentina, or even Messi, a look in. In fact, it neutralised him in a way no other team had managed to do. The final score may have been 1-0, but it felt more like 4-0.

Spain's run showed that, in football, philosophy almost always trumps chaos. And though it may look boring when compared with a midfielder dribbling past three players, the system, too, can be a beautiful thing.

VAR needs to be rebooted

This beauty was in sharp contrast to the brutishness of the Argentine players after losing a final they did not deserve to win, and the cries on social media about favouritism by the Video Assistant Referee (VAR) in the last two weeks of the tournament.

For those of us who watch league football all year, the inconsistency of VAR is not new. But the millions who tune into the sport once in four years found some of the calls appalling. In a world where reel and reel overlap more than ever, the inconsistent sparks conspiracy theories. And so the theory emerged that Argentina were being given an unfair advantage by a corrupt administration to ensure Messi got a perfect send-off.

The real problem here is not some giant plot involving referees from all over the world, but that VAR is broken and needs to be fixed. It tries to examine a subjective call by taking a second subjective call. That's not how replays should be used. Instead, VAR should make objective calls to overrule clear and obvious errors, as the Decision Review System (DRS) does in cricket. There, Hot Spot and Snicko tell you if the ball was edged, the tram lines of Hawk-Eye tell you if it was an LBW. These are objective yardsticks that can be applied uniformly.

So, the big takeaway: Use VAR only for offside calls—it's the one bit of objective tech available at this time—until you can develop tools that offer uncomplicated guidelines for other decisions. And remember the golden rule: Don't attribute to me that which can be adequately explained by incompetence.

(The views expressed are personal)

{ SOUND BITES } COLOUR PALATE

Hue's in the kitchen

Swetha Sivakumar



I ate plenty of mithai growing up. But the memory of one dish has stayed with me: a bowl of pink payasam from a temple in Kerala.

Its magic lay in two things: its luxurious texture, created by the long reduction of milk and the simmering of starches; and its unmistakable pink hue. Part of that colour came from the broken red rice used. But red rice is not the only path to pink payasam.

Pressure-cook milk and sugar together and the gentle caramelisation can add a brown hue that, when mixed with milk, looks pale pink. The ratio is vital here. The more sugar, the darker the hue. I use a quarter cup of sugar for every cup of milk.

Colour can be one of the most intriguing tricks to play with in the kitchen.

Humans instinctively associate certain tints with flavours. Good cooks understand this. Food marketers do too. So, in a number of foods, what begins as a genuine indicator of quality is often strategically recreated.

Take the dosa. A beautifully browned one instantly signals flavour (from the Maillard effect). One sees the dosa and immediately

pictures fluffy batter on a hot griddle, the drizzle of ghee, and the edges crisping up.

Shortcuts include adding naturally red-dish-brown foods such as fenugreek seeds or red rice to the traditional mix for the batter. A bit of sugar can also help, and that's a habit I'll admit I sometimes use at home.

Perfectly browned potatoes are often not perfectly browned either. That takes time, and just the right balance of low moisture, high heat and an alkaline environment.

Instead, look closely at a number of social-media posts and you'll find that which can be used to create the illusion of that delicious rosy, crisp texture.

Most mass-manufactured cheddar cheese, meanwhile, has changed colour completely, as companies chase the perfect hue.

It was the beta carotene in fresh grass that gave cow's milk its mild orange-yellow, a pigment that passed into milk fat, producing naturally yellow butter and cheese. Across most of the world, this was only possible in summer. The rest of the time, the cows ate grain and the pigment faded away. Meanwhile, buffaloes, goats and sheep convert beta carotene into colourless Vitamin A. So, even grass-fed, their milk could only produce white butter and cheese.

To keep things consistent, manufacturers began to add natural dyes to their cheese. Today, the deep orange tint from those ingredients, rather than the original pale yellow, has become part of cheddar's identity.

My favourite hue hack in the kitchen? A tablespoon of canned tomato paste, to give my curries a rich colour.

Fresh tomatoes tend to stay pinkish when cooked, because they hold so much water. It takes quite a long time—and plenty of tinkering with the rest of the dish—to get that water to evaporate and lead to a deeper red.

A spoon of paste delivers that rich red look and deep tomato flavour instantly.

(Email Swetha Sivakumar on ugradgradyn@gmail.com)



QR code at left to see the image, taken on a seemingly deserted street in Paris, is considered the first photograph containing a human: a man pausing to have his shoes polished, who was captured by accident. (Most people moved in and out of these early landscapes too quickly to be captured.)

Who, me?

That year, across the Atlantic, a 30-year-old American photographer in the US shot motionless and gazed at a makeshift camera for 15 minutes. Robert Cornelius had just taken the world's first selfie (Image 8 above). Portraits were now within reach. In a world of advances in printing, one man wondered: Could copies be possible?

English scientist William Talbot invented the negative-to-positive paper process in 1840. Instead of a metal plate, he used silver iodide to make paper light-sensitive, and thus created the negative.

Early witness

Once a camera could be trusted to faithfully preserve a moment, it began to serve as witness to history.

In the 1850s, Roger Fenton was commissioned by art dealership and prints publisher Thomas Agnew & Sons to document the Crimean War (1853-56; fought to keep Russia from expanding into the Ottoman empire). He travelled in a horse-drawn van fitted with a darkroom. Long exposure times meant there was little live combat recorded.

An 1855 image titled *The Valley of the Shadow of Death* (Image 6 above), however, shows a ravine littered with cannonballs—and still has historians arguing about whether it was staged.

Settler of arguments

Does a galloping horse lift all four hooves off the ground simultaneously?

Legend has it English photographer Eadweard Muybridge was trying to settle a wager with a racehorse owner, when he shot his famous sequence of brief-exposure photographs, in 1878. (See Image 12)



He lined a racetrack with boxy stereo-camera and proved that the horse does indeed lift all hooves off the ground.

Muybridge would later project those images at high speed, to create an illusion of movement so powerful that it laid the groundwork for cinema.

Smile!

The world's first point-and-shoot handheld camera was born a decade after the horse-ride. In 1888, it used a lens to project an image onto light-sensitive film, and required no skill or training to use.

The device was invented by American entrepreneur George Eastman. He called it the Kodak. It came with preloaded paper-gelatin film. Once the 100-image roll had been used, customers mailed the camera to the company, which developed the pictures, reloaded the film and mailed it all back.

Bandit's Roost

By the 1890s, photography was being used as a tool for social reform.

Images such as *The Bandit's Roost* (1888) by Danish-American photographer Jacob Riis, exposed the harsh realities of poverty largely hidden from public view. He used newly invented magnesium flash powder to illuminate the dark slums of New York, with

15. Smoke rises from the World Trade Center on 9/11, 2001.

16. Inside the Large Hadron Collider at CERN.

17. Canadian wildfires turn New York's sky orange, 2023.

18. India win the cricket World Cup, in 2011.

19. Gaza, 2023.

20. A familiar gesture? Cave art in Indonesia from 10,000 years ago.

their dank stairwells and overcrowded tenements. The images made headlines and eventually contributed to the passage of new affordable-housing laws.

Starry-eyed

By the 1950s, the technology was helping turn people into brands.

Elvis Presley's publicity team, for instance, used carefully curated press photos (posters, magazine covers and still from TV appearances) to craft his image as a star, in 1956.

Six decades later, social media would hand the reins of such image-building to the star themselves. In 2017, Beyoncé announced her second pregnancy with a single, Renaissance art-inspired portrait posted directly to Instagram. (See Image 5.) It quickly became the most-liked photo on the platform.

You and yours

Instagram, of course, changed everything. Launched in 2010, its first-ever image, taken by co-founder Kevin Systrom, was a yellow-filter photograph of a dog near a taco cart in Mexico. It changed our ideas of what counted as documentation.

In the collage above, trace how the lens has been present at humanity's seminal moments, from Earthrise in 1968 to the 9/11 attacks of 2001, India's 2011 World Cup win, American footballer Colin Kaepernick taking a knee in 2016, and the ongoing horrors of Gaza. Scan the QR code alongside for more: *The Bandit's Roost* view of New York; *Atkins's cyanotypes*; the horrors of the holocaust and the 2004 Indian Ocean tsunami.

Meanwhile, in 2023, another first: An AI-generated picture (Image 10 above) won a photography prize. German artist Boris Eldagsen says he created it hoping to spark conversation about the use of such tools. When it won a Sony world photo prize anyway, he declined to accept.

The women in the frame don't exist. It wasn't made using a camera. The jury thought that was an interesting use of the medium. He argues it isn't the same medium at all.

PHOTOS: WIMEDIA, GETTY IMAGES, SHUTTERSTOCK, EVENT HORIZON TELESCOPE, IT ARCHIVES, ASSOCIATED PRESS, AMRA FOR UNWRA

No one wants to eat a pale cheddar, a colourless dosa or a pink curry. Read on to see why that is. *ADORESTOCK*



wknd urban

Grand quest auto

Potholes, traffic, hawkers, honking... India's roads are not for beginners. In a wry twist, developers are working this chaos into videogames. Race against rickshaws, chase litterers for clues, dodge wedding bands, and wander through civic offices where nothing can be found. In-game, you get to bend the rules too

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People don't say "I love to drive" as much as they used to.

Traffic won't move. Potholes multiply nearly overnight, as do piles of road rubble. Vendors, hawkers and crowds spill over onto the streets... and even near-death encounters are simply part of the everyday. In a wry twist, game developers are now incorporating this chaos into videogame design, using it to add to the challenges of the plot. It's cathartic, they say, and no rules apply. So go ahead and shout back at the irate commuter in the next car; honk that horn and let it all out.

In Detective Dotsan (Masala Games: 2025), set largely in Ahmedabad and Mumbai, a hunt for a killer is derailed by wedding processions, gully cricket, movie shoots, a municipal office where no documents can be traced and, always, the chaotic traffic.

In Project Madras (due for release this year), players wend their way through Chennai's traffic signals, potholes and crowded Marina Beach. As they attempt to infiltrate the city's organised-crime network to crack open a conspiracy, they must contend with incessant honking and construction noise too.

In Raahi (Kalp Studio; scheduled for release next year), players take the wheel of an autorickshaw and drive through a fictional Goan town called Majli. The objective is to earn enough cash to buy the month-long tuk-tuk race by ferrying passengers about, chatting with locals, and making fun

and cooking Goan dishes for some extra cash. Hurdles to watch out for include expensive upgrades, and vehicle breakdowns.

"India has a very natural friction. It's not easy to achieve the simplest of things sometimes because there are so many people and so much going on all the time," says Shalin Shodhan, founder of Masala Games. "The natural friction makes for interesting gameplay."

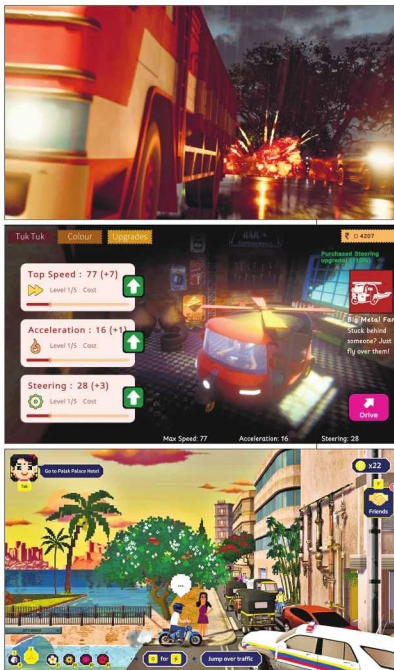
In his game, Detective Dotsan must learn the ways of riverside ghats, bargain with shopkeepers, chase people who litter and listen carefully at the chat stall. Each interaction earns him rewards or reveals clues to help with the investigation.

The gameplay is elevated by the fact that there are few repercussions for breaking the rules.

"You don't have to respect a traffic signal. The freedom to add to the chaos without repercussions is part of the appeal. This transforms everyday frustration into a form of entertainment," says Royston Ragul A, lead developer of Project Madras. "We really wanted our game world to behave like Chennai, where people are expressive on the roads, shout at traffic signals and honk a lot. We wanted to represent that."

Unlike the bulk of Indian videogames set in India, which tend to be based in myth and an ancient past, these reflect contemporary pet peeves, local slang, city landmarks, foods and personality types. Players may thus encounter vehicles going the wrong way on a one-way street, vendors popping up overnight where there weren't vendors before; milkmen, postmen and other fixtures that lend a city a lived-in feel.

The idea is to challenge the assumption that escape requires living a fantasy and leaving reality behind, says Siddharth Muppidi, chairperson of the Game Developers Association of India. "Such games let you role-play as somebody else in a familiar setting."



(From top) Stills from the videogames Project Madras (set in Goa) and Detective Dotsan (set in Ahmedabad and Mumbai).

Better tools, technology, and growing confidence among Indian developers are making it easier for developers to experiment and tell stories set in familiar environments.

"We wanted to offer something that's slice-of-life," says Alshat Sinha, design lead and co-founder of Kalp Studio. "How people actually live, and the connections they build."

For Abner Kapoor, founder of Civic Games Lab—whose releases include the card game Farzi, about misinformation; and the gamified platform Digital Naagrik, about digital rights—the shift is reflective of something larger: the decolonisation of gaming itself. "If fantasy is about escape, whose fantasy are we escaping into," Kapoor asks. "Why should our idea of an imagined world always have roots in Europe or America? The point is not simply to place an Indian character inside a borrowed format. The stories, conflicts, humour and mechanics should come from our cities, neighbourhoods, bazaars and adds."

His ideal such game, he adds, would be one set in the world of Saadat Mirza's classic Doodarad series Nukkad (1986), about the daily negotiations, tensions and small acts of survival that build a neighbourhood together. All of which sounds like a great step forward, but wouldn't it be nice if the roads—in-game and real-world, literal and metaphorical—could be smoother too?

{ CALL OF THE VALLEY } KONGTHONG

Name that tune: Welcome to Meghalaya's whistling village

Dipanjan Sinha

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In Kongthong, a person can be summoned without anyone saying their name. A melody rises from somewhere on the hillside. It may be sung or whistled. The person it is meant for hears it, recognises it and answers.

For generations, the people of Kongthong village in Meghalaya's East Khasi Hills have used melodies as names. It is the mother who composes the tune for each baby, soon after its birth. The melody emerges from the intimacy of caring for the infant, and from the love, relief and happiness of having brought a child into the world, villagers say.

The term for these tunes is Jingrwal lawbel, or Song-Name for the Ancestress. The tradition is rooted in the tribe's matrilineal structure. "Lawbel" is "ancestral mother of the clan". The song-name thus connects each individual with their wider maternal lineage.

"The melodies are not written down. There is no notation, formal musical training or song-naming ceremony involved," says Ritheli Khongait, a native of Kongthong and chairman of the Meghalaya Rural Tourism Cooperative Federation. "After recovering from childbirth, a mother may begin to shape the tune while holding, walking with or soothing her baby."

The tune can evolve with the child. A shorter version can be used when they are nearby. The full melody can carry across hills and fields. In a landscape where people may be separated by ridges and forests, the tune becomes a practical form of communication. Only the person may answer, Khongait says. "If a man is being called, his wife cannot respond in his place."

There are many origin stories for the tradition, adds National Award-winning Manipuri filmmaker Oinam Doren, whose documentary on this and other practices in the village is titled My Name is Eecow (2016). "One version speaks of a man fleeing attackers, climbing a tree, and using his tune to call to people in the village."

For centuries, if not millennia, this has

been the village's way. It was only when outsiders began to notice the melodies that Kongthong started to see itself through a different lens.

Social media has carried the tunes far beyond Meghalaya. Tourists now travel here to hear the song-names. The village, which had no tourist establishments in 2016, now has seven traditional bamboo cottages run by the village cooperative, one homestay, and a private resort under construction.

The village is working to ensure that the attention benefits but does not overrun them, Khongait says. He is among those collaborating with the village's Indigenous Agro Tourism Cooperative Society to build a model in which tourism can create opportunities for villagers, while protecting the culture and landscape.

They arrange Jingrwal lawbel whistling demonstrations, sell local produce such as honey and fruit, and help train young people for jobs in hotels and as tourist guides.

Tune back time

Perhaps the changes will keep the children from leaving, villagers say.

Currently, many are going where their songs can no longer reach them.

They typically leave as schoolchildren, since there is still no higher secondary school in or near the village. Many then enrol for further study at institutes in distant cities. They return changed, Khongait says, having adapted to another environment and become less connected to the customs of home, including their song-names.

A high school would help, he adds. Even a few more years spent in the hills may help them hold on to their songs when they leave. Leaving isn't easy either, says Shildaman Pohngong. 30. She works in a hotel in the state capital of Shillong and is closer to home now than she has been in recent years; previous jobs took her to Mumbai and Bengaluru. Her song-name has gone everywhere with her, she says.

"Wherever I go, people get to know about our traditions and these songs," Pohngong says. "Some people from our village feel shy, but I sing out my name for them whenever I get the chance."



A person's Jingrwal lawbel or song-name is shaped by the mother as she holds, walks or soothes her baby in its earliest days. PHOTO: PAASTAR KHONGKHE

India has a very natural friction. It's not easy to achieve the simplest of things sometimes. This natural friction makes for interesting gameplay.

SHALIN SHODHAN, founder of Masala Games, developers of the videogame Detective Dotsan

{ THE WAY WE WERE }

Poonam Saxena

Crossover tales

It's been so long, we think we know all there is to know about Partition. A new film and a rather old story offer proof that there will always be more lives to remember

The success of the Hindi film *Main* Vaapas Aaunga, now in theatres, featuring Naseeruddin Shah and Dilli Dossanji, has everyone talking about Partition-era literature again. Familiar names have resurfaced, chief among them that of the iconic Saadat Hasan Manto.

But there are many other writers whose work, while not primarily centred on Partition, tackled the theme in their own ways. In my last column, I mentioned Phanishwar Nath Renu, the writer from Purnea in Bihar, whose short story *Maare Gaye Gullam* was made into a film *Teesri Kasam* (1966). He is not a writer one associates with Partition. He is a chronicler of rural Bihar. Yet, when I read his best-known novel, *Maaila Anchal* (1954), I was moved by the story of one of his characters. I will recount it here.

Maaila Anchal is set in the 1940s, in a village in Purnea set against a superlative and caste divisions. But change is coming, slowly and inevitably, to Meriganj.

Even in this remote hamlet, villagers know of "Gandhi mahatma". There is a Congress outpost in Purnea, the Socialist party is making its presence felt, and a right-wing group in black tops is becoming active. But the Mahatma's aura is unmatched.

The village's most ardent devotee is a person with dwarfism named Bavandas, who is to me the most heroic character in the novel. During the Quit India movement, as a crowd tries to unfurl the tricolour in a courtyard, the police start to fire shots in the air. Bavandas makes his way through the legs of the policemen and plants the flag. He is arrested and goes to jail.

Bavandas has corresponded with Gandhi. He delivers speeches in his big, booming voice. He holds himself to Gandhian ideals, and fasts when he fails to live up to them. Then, on January 30, 1948, Gandhi is assassinated. Villagers listen as Nehru



Naseeruddin Shah and Dilli Dossanji in *Maaila Anchal* (1954; left) by Phanishwar Nath Renu.

announces the news on the radio, tears in his voice. Bavandas is devastated. He has no hope left, and decides to leave. He pulls a small packet from his jholi, which contains his correspondence with Gandhi. He looks at the letters one by one, as if for the last time, then gives the packet to a friend and fellow Gandhian, and asks him to hand them over to a senior Congress leader.

He catches a train headed east, to Kalimundipur, then walks to the banks of the Nagar River that flows through India and East Pakistan, like a border between the two. It is freezing cold. Bavandas has received a tip that dozens of bullock carts will come this way, loaded with smuggled goods such as garments, sugar and opium. He stands in the middle of the path. He prays to Bapu for strength. The carts are coming. There are about 50 of them. Seeing him, they come to a messy halt. The local policeman calls out "Kano hai?"

"Hum haan," he says. The policeman knows Bavandas, and tries to get him to move. He refuses.

The policeman runs to a nearby bungalow where the gangster Gammed-neta, a hawaldar and the supply inspector are partying. He

tells them what has happened. Is Bavandas alone, they ask.

"Yes. He's refusing to leave. Instructions are given: Let the bullock carts continue. But the animals refuse to budge. Kapa and the hawaldar have to twist their tails to force them forward. Bavandas is knocked down and crushed."

The killers throw his bloodied body onto the Pakistan bank of the river. On a routine patrol that afternoon, Pakistani policemen find the body and recognise it. This is the little man from the other side! He doesn't belong here.

The corpse is picked up, thrown into the river and vanishes. But the jholi, hung on a tree on the Indian bank, is so distinctive that Kapa identifies it immediately. As he rips it off its branch, a fragment of cloth remains.

Not long after, as devotees flock to Gandhi's memorial in Delhi, at Kalimundipur, an unnamed woman, sad and weary, sees the cloth and thinks it indicates a chithari pir or a tree regarded as a saint, to whom one must offer scraps of cloth as tribute. She tears a piece from the anchal of her sari, ties it to the tree, makes a wish and leaves.

Months go by. On Kalimundipur Ghat, another piece of cloth appears.

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{ THE SPORTING LIFE }

Rudraneil Sengupta

Medal detector

A reduced roster of just 10 disciplines at this year's Commonwealth Games will limit India's capacity to win. With no wrestling, cricket or badminton, hopes hinge on athletics: javelin throw, running, sprinting

The fading importance of the Commonwealth Games, and of the idea of the "commonwealth" itself, can be seen clearly at this edition of the multisport event. It opened in Glasgow on July 23, but features only half the number of sporting disciplines (just 10, down from 19 in the last edition).

That drop is because the 2026 Commonwealth Games were supposed to be hosted by Victoria, Australia. In 2023, Victoria withdrew, citing concerns over rising costs.

Glasgow, which hosted the event in 2014 (CWI is held every four years), offered to step in, under a few conditions: the city would use only existing infrastructure, and the roster of sporting disciplines would have to be smaller.

What does this mean for India? Birmingham 2022 went as expected, with the national contingent bagging 61 medals to finish fourth among 74 nations in the final tally, behind only England, Australia and Canada.

Thirty of those medals would not be possible at this edition. Many of the sports added are disciplines in which India tends to dominate at CWG: wrestling (we won medals in



all 12 categories in 2022; six of those gold, cricket (finished second, behind Australia), badminton (topped the medals tally with six three of those gold), hockey (the men won silver, albeit after an infamous thrashing by Australia; women won bronze), and table tennis (topped the medals tally with seven, including four gold).

Of these, athletics, swimming and cycling will account for the most medals. Historically, India has fared poorly in all three. This is because CWG, unlike in many other disciplines, features several world and Olympic champions in these three sports.

While swimming and cycling remain a struggle, athletics in India has seen a boom in the years since Neeraj Chopra's gold at the Tokyo Olympics in 2021 (India's first-ever gold in athletics at the Games).

Indeed, 28-year-old Chopra will headline the 125-strong Indian contingent, and his gritty on-field rivalry with Pakistan's Arshad Nadeem will likely be one of the highlights of this lean edition. Meanwhile, Indian javelin has seen such exponential growth that, for the first time in CWG history, there will be three javelin throwers from India in the mix, with Yash Vir Singh, 24, and Rohit Yadav, 25, being the others.

Beyond javelin too, Indian athletics has had an unprecedented year. 26 national records have fallen already, more than in any single year in the history of the sport in the country. Many of these record-breakers will be at CWG, including 5000m runner Parul Chaudhary, the Asian Games champion whose record-setting timing of 15:04.26 this year makes her the best in Asia by far.

Chaudhary, 31, is not among the medal favourites in Glasgow, though, because the world and Olympic champions from countries such as Kenya will be in the fray. The medal-winning times at 2022 were all under 15 minutes.

The 100m sprinter Gurinder Singh, 25, whose national record in May made him an instant star, may spring a surprise (given that the US, a top sprinting nation, is not part of the Commonwealth). The 2022 100m gold was won in 10:02 seconds, silver in 10:13, and bronze in 10:14. Gurinder's record stands at 10:08.

One great run, and he may do what no Indian has done since Milkha Singh in 1958: win a sprint medal at CWG.

(Email Rudraneil Sengupta on rudraneil@gmail.com. The views expressed are personal)

READ Poonam Saxena's last column, on the story behind the classic film *Teesri Kasam*

SPORT

Haunted for his name, Jhandu etches his identity in Glasgow

The heavyweight para powerlifter opened India's medal count with a bronze medal at the CWG

Shantanu Srivastava
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NEW DELHI: His name evokes north and luck, and Jhandu Kumar is acutely aware of that. So much so, it has helped him acquire the rare ability to laugh at himself. "I know I have a funny name. What can I do?" he asked on Saturday, hours after opening India's medal tally at the Glasgow Commonwealth Games with a para powerlifting bronze in the heavyweight (+73) division.

"You can either sulk at what life throws at you or make your way through with a smile. It's always better with the latter," he said on phone from Glasgow. Armed with that motto, an earnest smile, and some serious upper body strength, Jhandu, weighing 224kg, bench-pressed 190kg on his second attempt to clock 130.9 points at the Armadillo Arena, to finish third. Nigeria's Billuwan Idris took gold with 132.8 points while England's Matthew Harding was second (131).

At the CWG, powerlifting medals are decided using a bodyweight coefficient formula called pDOTS rather than the weight lifted alone. That's because athletes from different bodyweights compete together in the lightweight and heavyweight categories. The pDOTS calculator uses the athlete's weight and the best successful lift to determine the points.

Jhandu started the competition with 181kg before going for 190kg, a weight he knew would put him in medal contention. He cranked it up to 196kg but the bar brushed the overhead hook while going up, resulting a foul. A suc-

Know Jhandu Kumar

From: Nalandia, Bihar

Age: 29

Discipline: Para powerlifting

Category: Heavyweight (+73kg)

Training base: SAI NCOE, Gandhinagar



cessful lift would've fetched him 135.07 points, and a gold. "I was definitely going for gold but couldn't execute the technique well," he said.

Jhandu's phone hasn't stopped buzzing since. His family in Bihar's Harnaut town in Nalandia district stayed up late to watch him compete, and his proud parents have been busy fielding queries from the local press and distributing sweets in the neighbour-

hood. "I'm told it's a party at my place. It feels surreal. As recent as 2-3 years back, I could never dream of representing the country, forget winning a medal. People would laugh at me, call me names, and I would just smile back at them," he said.

For the better part of his 29 years, his first name made him a butt of jokes among friends, acquaintances and family members. A colloquial slang, 'jhandi'

is typically used to address someone who's seen as daft.

Born as Avinash, Jhandu contracted polio in both legs at the age of 5. His family, which sells vegetables for a living, spent all its means for his treatment, but nothing helped. An acquaintance then labelled him 'jhandu' for exhausting all his family's money. The name stuck. "Initially people would call me 'jhandu' lovingly, but soon it became a taunt," he

said.

Tired of the barbs, he went to a government office to get his name changed, but everyone in the office broke into hysterical laughter on hearing his name. "I thought if my name can bring happiness to so many people, maybe I shouldn't change it. I love my name," he said.

Name settled, Jhandu set out to find his identity. His first stop was the gym. "I thought it didn't

matter if my lower body was polio-struck. I could still work on my upper body." Soon, the gym became his safe place, barbells his best friends, and it was only natural that his life-altering inspiration would come from the weights room.

Egged on by his enthusiastic instructor, Jhandu took up para athletics in 2017, competing in the F55 shot put and discus throw events. During this period, strength training sparked his interest in powerlifting and he began competing in local events by 2019.

All this while, Jhandu made ends meet by selling vegetables on the pavement in Harnaut. Waking up before dawn, he would go to Bihar Sharif, a town over 30km from his place, to buy vegetables that he would sell during the day. Evenings were reserved for workouts where Jhandu bench-pressed twice his bodyweight. "Lifting gave me a sense of liberation. I really looked forward to my gym sessions."

Gradually, he developed an interest in powerlifting and began to train for the Nationals. To supplement his dietary needs, he needed more money. He drove an e-rickshaw, which he then sold to prepare for the 2023 Nationals. "I drove for 8-9 months but it was very taxing. I didn't have the energy to work out after ferrying passengers all day, and the returns weren't great either. I was still short of money, so I sold it," he said.

At the 2023 Nationals he failed in all three attempts, but it proved a turning point in his career as Rajinder Singh Barahia identified his potential and invited him to train at the SAI centre in Gandhinagar. "It has been an upward trajectory since. Next, I'd like to win medals at the Asian Para Games and the 2026 Paralympics," he said. They once laughed at his name, but it has finally brought a smile to the nation.

MAJOR ACHIEVEMENTS

2026 **BRONZE**
AT COMMONWEALTH GAMES, GLASGOW

2026 **BRONZE**
AT ASIA OCEANIA CHAMPIONSHIPS, BANGKOK

2026 **GOLD**
AT NATIONAL CHAMPIONSHIPS

2025 **BRONZE**
AT WORLD CUP, BEIJING

2025 **GOLD**
AT NATIONAL CHAMPIONSHIPS

CAREER BEST LIFT
206KG
AT KHELO INDIA PARA GAMES, 2025

GLASGOW CORNER

LE CLOS MAKES CWG HISTORY WITH RECORD 19TH MEDAL

South African swimmer Chad Le Clos became the most decorated male athlete in Commonwealth Games history after winning a bronze medal in the men's 4x100m freestyle relay. The record 19th medal took Le Clos past shooters Phil Adams of Australia and Mick Gault of England. "I shouldn't be crying at bronze, I should be crying at gold, but honestly this means the world," the 44-year-old Le Clos said on the Games website on Friday. Le Clos' Commonwealth haul was up to seven golds, four silvers and eight bronzes. And he may not be finished in the 100m pool — he's also entered in the 50m and 100m butterfly races. Le Clos made his CWG debut in 2010 in New Delhi, where he collected five medals at age 18. These are his fifth CWG. In a glittering career, he's also won four Olympic medals — one gold — and 16 world titles, mostly in butterfly. He plans to compete at his fifth Olympics in 2028 in LA.

LANGTON CONSCIOUS AFTER HEAVY FALL

England gymnast Gabriel Langton was conscious and speaking with doctors after being taken to hospital following a heavy fall during the men's team gymnastics final at the CWG, team officials said. The 19-year-old crashed headfirst to the floor after he came off the horizontal bar in the final round of the competition, prompting a lengthy halt as medical personnel rushed to his aid. Langton received treatment on the competition floor for several minutes before being placed on a stretcher, fitted with a neck collar and taken from the arena to hospital for further assessment. Langton was conscious, moving and speaking with doctors, team officials said. "We are grateful to the medical teams who responded immediately to provide assistance," Team England said in a statement.

SCOTLAND'S SCOTT SPLITS AUSTRALIAN SWIM DOMINANCE

Duncan Scott delivered host Scotland's first gold medal of the Commonwealth Games to break up Australia's dominance of the pool on the first day of action in Glasgow on Friday. With the programme nearly halved to just 10 sports, swimming is the highlight of the schedule across the opening weekend. Scott set a Games record of one minute, 56.38 seconds to win the 200m individual medley from New Zealand's Lewis Clareburt and England's Thomas Dean. The 29-year-old now has four Commonwealth golds and 14 medals in total. "It was a tough one because you really want to give the team some good momentum early doors and being one of the senior members of the team, the onus was on me," said Scott. "I was a bit nervous before that. Those boys made it tough, but I'm happy with that. It's a good way to start the meet." Elsewhere, Australia's green and gold topped the podium, with an extra bonus for those who emerged victorious.



Indira's Pinki Singh during the bowls women's pairs event.

Siwach wins, India advance in bowls

HT Correspondent
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NEW DELHI: Boxer Sachin Siwach survived a strong challenge from Canada's Keoma Al-Ahmadieh to enter the 60kg division pre-quarterfinals of the Commonwealth Games in Glasgow on Saturday.

Siwach, who hails from the boxing hub of Bhiwani, prevailed 4-1 in the first round at SEC Centre. The 26-year-old had beaten Al-Ahmadieh at the Turkey and Pinki Singh registered an earlier this year and at the World Cup in Kazakhstan last year.

The Canadian looked sharper in the opening exchanges but Siwach gradually settled into the contest, using crisp counter-punching to wrest back control. His accuracy in the closing stages of the round helped him edge 2-2, with three judges awarding him a 10-9 score.

Al-Ahmadieh came out aggressively in the second, taking the centre of the ring and looking to dictate the pace. Siwach, however, evaded the Canadian's attacks while catching him with swift counter combinations. He will next face England's William Hewitt in the Round of 16.

India maintained its momentum in bowls with Rupa Rani Turker and Pinki Singh registering a third straight win. They defeated Tonga 2-0 in the tie-breaker women's pairs third round match in Section B to stay on course for a semi berth.

Tonga made the brighter start,

taking a 1-0 lead after the opening end. But India responded strongly in the second end to level the scores. India maintained their dominance to claim the first set 5-2.

Tonga, however, staged a remarkable comeback to take the second set 6-4 and force a tie-breaker where the Indians rose to the challenge with Rupa putting the team ahead and Pinki closing it out.

However, Putul Sonowal tasted his first defeat after back-to-back victories, losing his men's singles third round match to Izzat Shameru Dzulkefle of Malaysia. Sonowal lost 0-2 (4-8, 8-9) in the Section D hour that lasted around one hour at the SEC Hall 3.

India's 3X3 wheelchair basketball team had a difficult start to their campaign as they lost 16-10 to Wales in their first Group B match. They will take on Scotland and Nigeria in their next two games on Monday.

There was disappointment in the pool as well with Dhakshan Shashikumar finishing seventh in Heat 3 of 400m freestyle, clocking 3:58.09. National record holder Aryan Nehra also fell short of the top-eight cut-off after clocking 4:00.26 in Heat 4. India also missed out on a para-swimming medal after Karthik Budgina finished fourth in men's 100m freestyle S13 final.

In the able-bodied event, Olympian Srihari Nataraj failed to make the men's 50m backstroke final, finishing a disappointing seventh in the semi-finals.

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NEW DELHI: As far as hyperboles go, coach James Hillier calling the rivalry between sprinters Gurinder Singh and Animesh Kujur "all-out war on tracks" may have few contestants.

Scratch a little deeper though and you'll get the drama there. Usain Bolt vs Justin Gatlin or Ben Johnson vs Carl Lewis, but for a nation parched for relevance on the athletics track, Gurinder Singh and Animesh challenging each other over 100m will do.

They will be in action in 100m and 200m respectively at the Commonwealth Games, marking a first for Indian athletics in the two elite events at CWG. Athletics at Glasgow will run from July 27 to August 1.

Gurinder Singh and Animesh qualified after a memorable two days at the Federation Cup in Ranchi in May where the 100m national record changed hands three times. The top-five 200m timings feature Animesh three times, including the top two.

While Indian athletics over the past few years has unearthed a decent group in javelin and horizontal jumps, this is perhaps the first real surge in sprints. Gurinder and Animesh are consistently pushed by Amian Borgohain, Manikanta Hoblihar and Pranav Gurav. All five train at Reliance Foundation with Martin Owens training. Owens, Hillier guiding the others. "The first thing you notice about these guys is mutual respect. They get along very well. They push each other and bring different skills, strengths and personalities," says Hillier.

Amian, the senior most in the group, aged 26, is like a broody hen. We have our heated moments too because all of us are very competitive and the testosterone is forever raging, but that's all in good spirit," says Amian, who held the 200m national record (20.52 secs) for three years before Animesh bettered it in 2025, clocking 20.32 secs.

The 28-year-old, currently recovering following a bout of dengue, gets pep talk from youngsters. They are all very sweet. They keep telling me, 'Bhaiya you'll come back



Animesh Kujur (L) and Manikanta Hoblihar, Reliance Foundation

stronger." We spend the better part of the year together, so we are like family," he says.

When Amian lost his mother last year, the group rallied around him to help deal with the loss. "It was a very difficult time, just being with these boys comforted me. I regularly go to Manikanta to share my thoughts

and insecurities, and vice-versa," he says.

Amian and Manikanta were on the same page in the last two months, backing France to win the FIFA World Cup. "We shared the sorrow of France crashing out just being with these boys comforted me. I regularly go to Manikanta to share my thoughts

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A quiz on the week's development.



RESULTS (INDIANS ONLY)

GYMNASTICS

Men's team final and individual qualification
Tapan Mohanty and Yogeshwar Singh qualified for all-around final
Swathi KP and Tapeswarath Das in reserve list

PARA SWIMMING

Men's S13 100m freestyle final
RVBK Budgina finished 4th
Iman Ali ended 7th

SWIMMING

Men's 50m backstroke semi-finals
Srihari Nataraj ended 7th, failed to qualify for final

PARA POWERLIFTING

Women's heavyweight final
Kasthuri Rajamani ended 12th
Men's heavyweight final
Jhandu Kumar won bronze
Sudhir ended 6th

WHEELCHAIR BASKETBALL

Women's Pool B
India lost 1-6 to Wales



Men's 60kg Round of 32
Sachin Siwach beat **Keoma Al-Ahmadieh** (CAN) 4-1

BOWLS

Women's pairs, Group B
Indira beat Tonga via tiebreak
Men's singles, Group D
Putul Sonowal lost 0-2 to **Izzat Shameru Dzulkefle** (MAS)

SWIMMING

Men's 400m freestyle heats
Dhakshan Shashikumar and **Aryan Nehra** failed to qualify for final



COMMONWEALTH GAMES 2026

INDIANS IN ACTION TODAY

ARTISTIC GYMNASTICS

Men's all-around final

Tapan Mohanty (4:30pm)

Men's 55kg Round of 16

Jaduman Singh Mandegamb vs Sumana Rehman, PAK (11:45pm)

Women's all-around final

Pranati Nayak, Nishika Aggarwal, Protishtha Samanta, Eshtiaq Revaak (10:30pm)

Men's 65kg Round of 16

Aditya Pratap Yadav vs Nuhu Batte, UGA (12:45am, Monday)

BOWLS

Women's pairs, Group B

India vs Namibia (1pm)

India vs England (10:05pm)

Men's singles, Group D

Putul Sonowal vs Shaun James Parris, MJI (7:55pm)

BOXING

Men's 54kg Round of 16

Preeti Pawar vs Deborah Mteje, MAW (10:45pm)

Women's 48kg

Mirabai Chanu (6:30pm)

Men's 65kg

Raja Mathupandhi (11pm)

medal tally

COUNTRY	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
Australia	6	2	5	13						
Nigeria	3	3	3	0	6					
Scotland	2	2	2	0	4					
England	1	4	3	8						
Canada	1	0	2	3						
INDIA	0	0	1	1						

Competition, camaraderie fuel India's fast men

helping Manikanta get a hang of the FIFA video game. "Mani bhaiya has a really good sense of humour. He is one of those guys who can take a joke on him," says Swathi, from Spangya, Poland where he and Gurinder trained ahead of CWG. "I regularly go to him for advice because he is a very patient guy. He is also a very experienced sprinter, and sometimes little nuggets of information from him can make a huge difference," he says.

"All of us are very different sprinters," explains Manikanta. "Guri is the fastest of the blocks, Amian, when fully fit, has a great finish while Animesh is great at maintaining top speed. He sets the stage for an exciting finish which Gurinder wins with his extra bonus for those who emerged victorious."

All this bonhomie has little bearing on the tracks. In the Federation Cup semi-final, shortly after breaking Animesh's 100m national mark (10.18 secs) by clocking 10.17 secs, Gurinder stood trackside to cheer for his rival as he settled into the blocks. The 23-year-old obliged, bettering the record (10.15 secs). He set the stage for an exciting finish which Gurinder won with another NR (0.09 secs). "There is, of course, very stiff competition among us. Sprints are decided by very thin margins, so we really push hard in training. When we run or train together, sometimes the coaches have to step in thinking we might injure ourselves," says Amian. "When Animesh went past my NR, I was delighted for him but I also fired myself up. This is what I was missing when I was training by myself in Punjab," he says.

"I am enjoying the rivalry with him," Animesh says. "Both of us want to be the fastest man in the country. Both of us want to run sub-10. But there can only be one hero, one fastest man," he adds, showmanship intact.



Ishan Kishan was named Player-of-the-Match for his 44-ball 81 against Zimbabwe on Saturday. AFP

Ishan and Tilak help India win, seal series

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NEW DELHI: India sealed the three-match T20I series after a commanding all-round display saw them thump Zimbabwe by 90 runs in the second game at Harare on Saturday, taking a 2-0 lead. India rode on impressive contributions from Ishan Kishan (81-44b) and Tilak Varma (60*-26b) before a disciplined bowling performance settled the issue.

The visitors, under skipper Shreyas Iyer, took an unassailable lead. Defending a huge 20/5, India barely allowed Zimbabwe to settle into the daunting chase. The hosts were eventually bowled out for 129 after losing five wickets inside the first nine overs, effectively ending the contest long before the finish.

Zimbabwe briefly threatened through Brian Bennett, who hit 32 off 19 deliveries. The opener welcomed debutant pacer Yash Thakur with a six and a four in quick succession. However, Thakur (2/30) responded by forcing Bennett into a mistimed ramp shot that was taken by wicket-keeper Kishan.

That breakthrough triggered a collapse as India's bowlers tight-

ened the screws. While Ryan Burl (20) and Tadiwanashe Marumani (24) offered fleeting resistance, the hosts never built a meaningful partnership.

Abhishek Sharma proved an unlikely star with the ball, claiming 3/17 with his left-arm spin, while Thakur and Prince Yadav (2/10) chipped in with two wickets apiece. Even Varma rolled his arm over to enter the wickets column as India wrapped up the innings in 17.5 overs.

The victory helped Iyer secure his first T20I series win as captain after suffering back-to-back series defeats against Ireland and England. "I feel it's all about the attitude. Don't dwell too much on previous performances. Keep moving forward and, more importantly, stay in the present. You've got to maximise every opportunity you get. Tomorrow is another opportunity, so we're looking forward to it," said Iyer after the match.

Earlier, India's innings recovered impressively after a shaky start. Asked to bat, the visitors slipped to 29/2 following the early dismissals of Abhishek and the in-form Vaibhav Sooryavanshi.

Kishan, however, steadied the innings with maturity before shifting gears superbly. He first

stitched together a 66-run stand with Iyer (25) before adding a match-winning 94-run partnership with Tilak Varma.

The wicketkeeper-batter reached his fifty in 31 balls but accelerated brilliantly thereafter, adding 31 runs in 13 more deliveries. Bennett's off-spin disappeared for consecutive boundaries, while Brad Evans bore the brunt of Kishan's late assault.

Tilak complemented him perfectly with an unbeaten fifty after recent criticism over his strike rate. The left-hander brought up his half-century in just 23 balls and showcased timing and power, striking three successive boundaries off Muzarabani before launching Evans over midwicket for a towering six.

The duo's calculated aggression helped India add 61 runs in the final five overs, ensuring that Zimbabwe were left chasing an imposing target that ultimately proved far beyond reach.

Towards the end, Rinku Singh (12) and Shivam Dube (6*) also provided some handy hits to help India post that total.

Brief scores: India 219/5 in 20 overs (I Kishan 81, T Varma 60*) beat Zimbabwe 129 in 17.5 overs (B Bennett 32, A Sharma 3/17) by 90 runs.

Norris takes Hungary pole, Hamilton penalised

BUDAPEST: Defending Formula 1 champion Lando Norris took his first pole position of 2026 when he snatched it from Lewis Hamilton by just 0.012 of a second at the Hungarian Grand Prix on Saturday.

Hamilton was on course for a record-extending 105th pole position, and first in a full Grand Prix since Hungary in 2023,

before Norris darted through to take it away. Then a penalty dropped Hamilton to fifth. "It's been a while," Norris said. "I felt confident all weekend."

Norris felt he could easily have gone much faster if he'd had time for another run to iron out mistakes. "I had the confidence to push more," he said. "I got it to unexplored territory

from what happens to the balance when I push it that next level, and I lost a bit of time in a couple of places."

Norris added that upgrades to McLaren's car give him confidence for Sunday's race, but "it's a long race ahead tomorrow and it's going to be a difficult one."

Charles Leclerc took third for Ferrari but will start second. AP

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THE WEEK THAT WAS

A quiz on the week's development.



Anahat crowned world junior squash champ

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MUMBAI: Even as Anahat Singh was taking rapid strides on the professional squash tour, a long-standing goal lingered almost desperately in her mind — the world junior title. She kept having a crack at it and kept falling short.

By the Niagara Falls in Canada's Ontario, she finally made the leap. And with it scripted history for the country. Anahat, 18, became India's first world junior squash champion when she defeated Ruqayya Salem of Egypt 11-3, 11-7, 11-9 in the girls' final of the 2026 World Squash Junior Championships on Saturday.

The Indian, ranked 20th in the world and seeded No.1 in the event, played every bit like the favourite through the week, showing no signs of pressure or nerves in her quest to upgrade her medal colour in her final crack at the title as a junior.

That wasn't always the case for this highly-talented teen who has been growing in stature among the pros but kept falling short in squash's most prestigious junior event.

In the previous edition, Anahat returned with a bronze after losing in the semi-finals despite being among the top contenders in the draw.

The semi-finals was as far as she had been to even in the editions before that. Every time the



Anahat Singh. HT

box remained unticked, and the desperation only grew.

And so, once she finally got the job done, she flung her racquet and looked straight towards her team and parents who were cheering on from the stands.

"I still feel like I'm dreaming," Anahat said in her on-court interview seconds after the win. "This tournament has been the worst for me, losing in semis and quarters in the last few years... This was my last year, so I knew that this was my only chance to win the tournament. This means a lot."

Less than 24 hours after becoming the first Indian since Joshna Chinappa in 2005 to reach the final of the junior worlds, Anahat began the final on the fast lane.

The top seed completely dominated the second-seeded Egyptian across the first two sets, giving away just 10 points. Ruqayya put up a fight in the third set and even took a two-point lead for 8-6 before Anahat steadied the ship and took it home.

The semi-finals was as far as she had been to even in the editions before that. Every time the

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Mohun Bagan beat East Bengal 1-0

KOLKATA: Mohun Bagan Super Giant combined clinical finishing with resolute defending to edge arch-rivals East Bengal 1-0 in the pre-season derby that kicked off the Durand Cup here on Saturday. Sahal Abdul Samad scored the winner in the 52nd minute.

Sinner, Djokovic pull out from Montreal

MONTREAL: Wimbledon champion Jannik Sinner and 24 times Grand Slam winner Novak Djokovic have withdrawn from next month's US Open tune-up

event in Montreal, tournament organisers said on Friday.

Ex-India cricketer Chauhan booked

DURG: An FIR has been registered against former India cricketer Rajesh Chauhan for allegedly cheating a man of more than ₹15 lakh on the pretext of offering him a transport contract with a steel company, police said on Saturday. The case was registered at Mohun Nagar police station on Friday on the directions of a local court under Section 316(2) (criminal breach of trust) of the BNS.



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